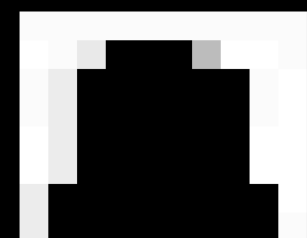
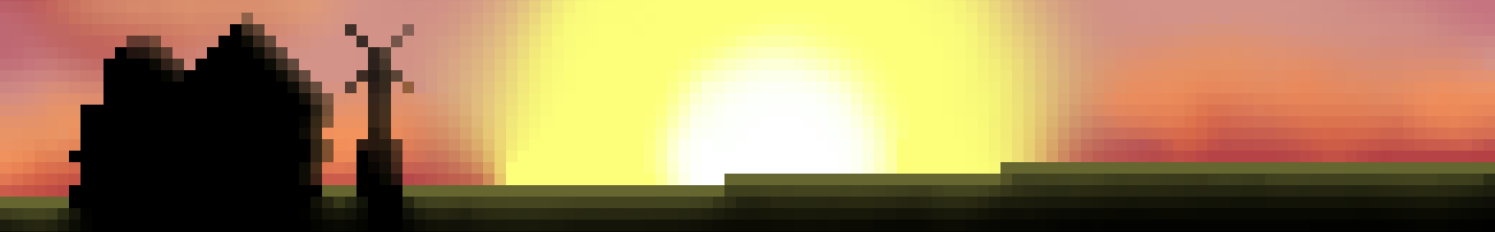


*Pink*

*Mourning*



PINK MOURNING

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A Play in Two Acts

by

Andrew

## Cast of Characters

Andrew A.K.A. Mindmeld: A teenager; Not much to note.

Teen Demon: A teenager (sort of); An immortal monster learning to live with humans; Hates meatloaf.

Tori A.K.A. Tinkerer: The "mother" of Tara, Teen Demon, Mindmeld, and Markie; Widow.

Markie A.K.A. Mark - 3: Can play the theremin; Working on the other skills; A robot; Technically a teenager.

Tara A.K.A. Emerald Earwig: Has a superpowered anklet that can form any weapon; Still coping with a breakup.

Blademaster: Reforming former leader of villainous group; Mentor to Mindmeld.

Morgan A.K.A. Microcosm: Daughter of Micro Man; A nasty villain.

Dom A.K.A. Momentum: Has grappling hooks; Just learning about toxic masculinity.

Emerson A.K.A. Burnout: A speedster struggling with the responsibility of their powers.

Abraham: A trained psychologist; The leader of the anxiety group; Likes tea.

Atomsplitter: Legendary super villain;  
Definitely dead.

Young Momentum

Momentum's Mother

Momentum's Father

Young Tara

Scientist

Dr. Iticus

Tara's Mother

Tara's Father

Tara's Suit: Tara's woman in the anklet;  
Always watching for threats.

Wendigo Woman: Criminal with lots of  
emotional baggage; Irritated by Teen Demon.

Beekeeper: Criminal with minimal emotional  
baggage; Enjoys Teen Demon.

Rider: The calm, cool, and collected "aunt".

Bat: A bat; Very big.

Dragonfly: The nervous yet plucky "aunt".

Philosopher: Pillbug-Man's best buddy; Likes  
Greek philosophers a little too much.

Tensile: Pillbug-Man's most competent student.

Stupendous Man: ~~Alive.~~ Dead.

Act 1

Scene 1

*The stage is split into three separate settings. The center and right-most sections are dark. The left-most is lit.*

*On the left side, Mindmeld is in his room, looking at the books on his shelf. The walls of his room are lined with bookshelves and his bed is the only piece of furniture.*

MINDMELD

Pink Skies . . . no. They're Safe . . . no.  
Rosewood . . . no. Where is that book I'm  
looking for?

*The spotlight shines on Mindmeld. He  
looks at the audience.*

MINDMELD

Oh! I did not see you there! It has been a  
while since we have communicated. Perhaps I  
should catch you up to where we are now. It  
has only been a few weeks or so, but so much  
has changed!

*"Harder Before It Gets Easier" by David  
Wax Museum begins playing as he walks  
through the door connecting the left-  
most section to the middle section.*

*The left-most section dims and the center section lights up. The spotlight follows him. In this section, Tara and Teen Demon are sitting on a bed in Tara's room listening to music. Mindmeld speaks as he walks across the room.*

MINDMELD

In case you are wondering, this is not what she is listening to right now. You have not missed much with her. It has mostly been some crying, moping, sobbing, and more crying. I could talk more about it, but who really wants to hear about that?

Teen Demon is Teen Demon. He is still his wonderful self.

*Mindmeld rolls his eyes.*

I love my brother, but I must admit I know more about him than I would care to.

*Mindmeld walks through the door connecting the center section to the right-most section. The center section dims as the right-most section lights up. Microcosm is sitting on the ground in Markie's room. Markie is currently playing the theremin which is the only item in her otherwise empty room.*

MINDMELD

Markie and Microcosm have been building a bit of a friendship, although none of us know

that. She is getting better at playing the theremin.

*Mindmeld pauses briefly to listen to the theremin, even though it can't be heard over the music playing.*

*He walks back through the door to the center section of the stage. The rightmost section dims as the center lights up. The center section is now the kitchen where Tinkerer and Blademaster are sitting with each other. The walls are lined with old, colorful wallpaper with picture of fruit on them.*

#### MINDMELD

These two have been working together recently and . . . I will just let you hear it from them!

*The spotlight moves to focus on the table.*

*The sound of a grandfather clock ticking fades in as the music fades out. Upon further inspection, it is apparent that there are two cups of tea on the table. One is full and the other is empty.*

#### BLADEMASTER

Andrew's training is going well.



*He looks into the empty teacup and holds it so the audience can see nothing is in it.*

Did you leave this out for me?

TINKERER

*Tinkerer doesn't look up.*

Sure. Thanks for training him.

BLADEMASTER

Anything for Stupendous Man's wife. He was a good man.

TINKERER

*Tinkerer looks up at him. Slightly aggravated.*

You know, I'm defined by more than our marriage. I loved him, but I wish people wouldn't just view me as an extra to him. He's gone now and I'm the one that's raising these kids here.

BLADEMASTER

I'm sorry. I did not mean it like that.

TINKERER

I know. I'm sorry. I don't mean to be rude. It's just he's been gone for so long and I'm trying to finally accept that, but people

always keep reminding me that he should be here.

BLADEMASTER

It's hard to figure out who you are meant to be without your spouse. You saw with me that I could have gone forever, never finding that new version of me.

TINKERER

We're glad to have you here.

BLADEMASTER

As am I glad to be here. You knew I could make it to the other end. You will too.

*Blademaster gets up and walks off the stage by exiting through the door to the left-most section. The sound of the clock ticking fades out and the spotlight shines back on Mindmeld.*

MINDMELD

Phew. Got a little intense there for a second.

*Mindmeld pulls at his shirt then continues through the door to the left-most section which lights up as the center section dims. Mindmeld is back in his room.*

MINDMELD

What about me, you may ask.

Well, I am doing just great! Yes, I did discover my dad, also my greatest role model, was a robot and I never truly knew him. Yes, I watched my maternal figure reform his corpse with her backpack into armor so she could fight her partner, sort of, which still is weird. Yes, I was given powers at a young age, and I cannot remember anything before them, including if I even wanted them. Yes, my mind is full of memories that aren't mine but that does not really matter.

I think the more interesting story is the tragedy of Tara crying about breaking up with Arthur for over a hundred pages. I think there is a lot more we could delve into there. We could get at least three more books out of that. That drama was why you read the first book after all, right? No need to focus on me! Nothing to see here.

*Mindmeld is interrupted by a knock. The spotlight fades from him.*

MINDMEELD

Come in!

*Tinker enters from the door to the center section of the stage. She walks in and sits down on Mindmeld's bed.*

TINKERER

Just making my rounds before bed. How you doing, Honey? Read any good books today?

MINDMELD

Yep! I read this really good book called *The Economy of Prestige: Prizes, Awards, and Cultural Value* by James English.

TINKERER

*A beat to process that title.*

Wow, what a suitable name for a person who wrote such a book. Anything I should know from it?

MINDMELD

Eh. Capital intraconversion, postcolonial societies, and prizes are deeply intertwined.

TINKERER

Good to know. I'll keep that one on the mind.

*She gets up and kisses Mindmeld on the forehead.*

Night, Son. Love you!

*Tinkerer gets up and walks toward the door.*

MINDMELD

Night, Mom. Love you too.

*BLACKOUT*

*END SCENE*

## Scene 2

*The stage is split into three separate settings. The left and right-most sections are dark. The center is lit.*

*In the center, the anxiety support group sits in a semicircle on folding chairs. They are in a quiet room lit by some warm lamps. A bin full of candy sits on the center table along with a selection of colorful fidget toys.*

*Tara, Momentum, Burnout, and Abraham sit in a semicircle facing the audience. Tara is on the left side of the circle and Momentum is on the right. None of them are wearing their superhero costumes.*

*Tara has her legs crossed, Momentum has his arms crossed, and Burnout is playing with one of the fidget spinners they picked up from the table.*

ABRAHAM

*He takes a sip of his bottled iced tea then speaks.*

It is a pleasure to get a chance to meet with such a talented group of individuals. Your mentors all have told me so many wonderful things about each of you. I feel this will be a very productive group. I hope you all feel comfortable sharing your thoughts, but you will never be mandated to do so. Although, we

are all on the same team here and if you do decide to share, I think you will find that a lot of people here will echo the same sentiment.

Let's start with names, pronouns, and powersets.

*Tara seems surprised to hear him mention powers.*

Don't be afraid. I have been made well aware what sort of individuals I am working with. I'm on your side. I think you'd be surprised how much I work with people similar to you.

I'll go first. My name is Abraham, I use he/him pronouns, and my power is listening.

*Abraham laughs quietly to himself.*

*The room sits quiet for a beat.*

TARA

I can go first. My name is Tara, I use she/her pronouns, and I have this special anklet attached to me which gives me the ability to form any weapon.

*Tara is wearing a green shirt and jean overalls.*

BURNOUT

My name is Emerson, I use she/they pronouns, and I can run fast. Although, it isn't like

the movies. I am still restricted by a normal human's stamina so don't expect tornadoes or something from me.

*Burnout is wearing sweatpants and a t-shirt with the WLU logo on it.*

MOMENTUM

Both of those powers are so cool. Don't be surprised if I steal those for a story idea in my Brigade universe which is my superhero universe and I have all these characters and stories lined up, although I haven't written them. Sorry, rambling.

I don't even have powers. I just have this grapple system I use to swing around so I can kick villains. I don't have blasters or something. That's name, powers . . . oh, and um, he/him pronouns.

BURNOUT

I mean I just usually punch people, so what you are doing isn't too far off from what I do.

MOMENTUM

You are totally right. This group is already helping.

ABRAHAM

Excellent. Hopefully over time we will all find this beneficial.



*Burnout sets down their fidget spinner.*

Please feel free to take some candy from the pot too. The more you take, the less I eat.

*Momentum reaches into the container and pulls out a chocolate bar. He unwraps it as Abraham speaks.*

We are all here because we have anxious thoughts. I do too.

Something I want us to think about is where these anxious thoughts may originate from. You don't have to tell me right now but try and narrow it down. It could be a collection of conversations—

*The stage dims as a spotlight shines on Burnout. Burnout takes heavy breaths in and out as recordings of voices play from the speakers.*

#### VOICES

*At once*

--Save us!

--Please don't let me die!

--Take me first!

--Burnout, we are over here! Get my daughter first.

--I have kids at home. Don't let me leave them.

*The spotlight fades away as the stage lights back up.*

ABRAHAM

--or one specific thing you've watched--

*The stage dims as a spotlight shines on Momentum. He taps his feet against the ground and briefly looks behind at the clock.*

*The right segment of the stage lights up to reveal Young Momentum, Momentum's Mother, and Momentum's Father. This segment of the stage is halved between a living room on one side of the wall and a kitchen on the other.*

*Young Momentum lays on a couch in the living room playing on his phone. He has one earbud in, and the other hanging out. His parents stand in the kitchen. Momentum's father is cutting vegetables for dinner.*

MOMENTUM'S MOTHER

GOD DAMN IT! You forgot to pick up the eggs I needed for dinner. You think you're so astute, but you can't even remember some eggs. You're a real dipshit.

*Young Momentum takes out his other earbud and adjusts himself, so he faces the wall to the kitchen.*

MOMENTUM'S FATHER

Can you keep it down? He's in the other room. I'm sorry. It slipped my mind after work. I'll go out and get some now.

MOMENTUM'S MOTHER

He can't hear anything. He's too busy on his phone. You know who didn't forget stuff? Samuel. He knew his shit. That was a man that really knew how to please a woman.

*Momentum's Father rubs the bridge of his nose with his fingers.*

MOMENTUM'S FATHER

Why do you always have to bring him up? If you really liked him so much then why didn't you marry him?

*Young Momentum gets up and exits the stage.*

MOMENTUM'S MOTHER

You know, sometimes I wish I had picked him.

*The right side of the stage dims. The spotlight fades away as the center section of the stage lights back up.*

ABRAHAM

—or repeated events—

*The stage dims as a spotlight shines on Tara. She reaches down to her ankle and fidgets with her anklet.*

*The left segment of the stage lights up to reveal Young Tara, Tara's Mother, and Tara's Father. They all sit around a table eating dinner.*

YOUNG TARA

I just don't know why he stopped texting me.  
I thought it was going well between us.

TARA'S FATHER

I'm sorry. I just know there's a great person  
waiting out there for you.

YOUNG TARA

But when? My first year of high school is  
almost over and no one even glances at me.

*Tara's mother sets down her utensils.*

TARA'S MOTHER

Maybe if you dressed a little nicer a guy  
would take a look at you. You're always  
wearing those overalls. They're gonna think  
that you are a farmer or something.

TARA

*Quietly*

I like the overalls . . . I think they look cool. Right, Dad?

TARA'S FATHER

I—Your mother knows best about these sorts of things.

TARA'S MOTHER

I'm just trying to tell you what everyone at school is thinking.

*The left side of the stage dims. The spotlight fades away as the center section of the stage lights back up.*

ABRAHAM

—or any number of things. Narrowing it down may help you better understand it because at the end of the day anxiety is something natural like feeling happy or sad. It is healthy to feel some anxiety as it is our body trying to protect itself, but as with all things too much can make you sick. Together . . .

*A spotlight shines on Tara as the stage dims. A voice echoes out from the speakers.*

TARA'S ANKLET

You getting all this?

TARA

*Whispering*

Yes! I am. Stop talking.

TARA'S ANKLET

Alright. I just wanted to make sure because getting this down might be the difference between life and—

*The spotlight dims and the center section of the stage lights back up.*

ABRAHAM

You okay, Tara? You were muttering something.

TARA

Sorry. Just talking to myself . . . Erm, probably not good to say that here. I was talking to my anklet. They're sentient, but not always respectful of when others are talking.

MOMENTUM

That's so cool. My grappling gear doesn't talk to me . . . just Tensile . . .

ABRAHAM

It's no worries at all. If your anklet ever needs to share something, you are more than welcome to speak for it. All thoughts are welcome here.

Who is Tensile?

#### MOMENTUM

A good friend. She goes to the same school as me, although she is kinda mean sometimes.

#### ABRAHAM

I'm glad you have a good friend. As I was saying, we are going to work together as a team to—

*The stage slowly dims as Abraham speaks.*

*The left-most section lights up. The center and right-most sections are dark.*

*On the left side, Tara and Teen Demon sit on her freshly made bed. The window is dark as it is late at night. The slanted roof above them is visible making the room feel a little small. "Bird's Don't Sing" by TV Girl plays in the background, presumably on Tara's phone. Tara is laying against the head of her bed with a pillow between her and the wood.*

*Teen Demon is sitting cross-legged on the other side of the bed rocking back and forth. His green body is a darker*

*color than Tara's green pajamas. A mask covers his face and a thin tail flicks around in the air. Crickets chirp in the background.*

TARA

Quit rocking around. It's driving me crazy.

TEEN DEMON

You lack the childlike spirit you should have at this stage in your development.

*Teen Demon stops rocking.*

TARA

And you possess an attitude you shouldn't. Anyway, what do you think of this song?

TEEN DEMON

It sounds weird.

TARA

That's the point.

TEEN DEMON

What is it even about?

*Teen Demon shrugs his arms.*

I thought some birds did sing.



TARA

It's not really about birds. The birds not singing and falling out of the sky is meant to be weird, which lines up with a partner leaving you randomly.

TEEN DEMON

Hmm. Yeah. That doesn't really make sense but that's okay because I just wanted to demonstrate compassion by asking you about it.

TARA

Huh?

*A beat.*

TEEN DEMON

Here, I'll keep going. Is that all the song is about?

TARA

Not quite. He tells his ex to not listen to the band's music because she may pick up on references to their old relationship.

TEEN DEMON

Is it okay for him to just make music that references someone else?

TARA

When doesn't art reference someone?

*They listen to the music until the song finishes playing. Teen Demon gets up from the bed. Tara continues to scroll on her phone.*

TEEN DEMON

*Flatly*

That was an emotionally challenging trip of a song. Yep.

*Speaking normal.*

Hey, I thought you decided to take control of your life again after fighting Mark One. Are you not fixed? Why must you attend this anxiety group?

*Tara looks over to Teen Demon.*

TARA

I made the decision, but it's a long process to make that a reality. This group should be an important step, plus the better my mental health is the stronger the suit becomes.

TEEN DEMON

Are you excited about it?

TARA

Maybe. It just is all so much with it happening every single day. I know it sounds weird, but I feel guilty joining it. I don't feel like my anxiety is real enough. My brain doesn't feel broken. I just get really anxious thinking about relationships, but I should be able to control that. Like, some people faint from their anxiety and stuff. All I do is get a little scared.

It seems like by joining this group I am officially telling the world that I have anxiety. It makes it seem real and maybe sounds even worse than what I actually have. Does that make sense?

#### TEEN DEMON

Do not feel guilty. If Tinkerer thought it was a good idea for you to join the group then it is a good idea. I am far from understanding human's little brains, but I do think it is intriguing how great of an effect a few words can have on someone. If just a few words can help, who knows what all the words you may hear in group will do for you?

Besides, I need you to join this group because I am seeing Wendigo Woman and the villains so I need you to tell me every single thing that happens there so I can mimic it.

#### TARA

God help her if you are the best she's got.

TEEN DEMON

I think if God wanted to help her, she wouldn't be in a jail cell. I think a demon is all she has, luckily you have more than that.

TARA

Hmm. Thanks, TD . . . I think. Goodnight.

*Tara waves to him.*

TEEN DEMON

*Teen Demon grabs the door handle and opens the door to backstage.*

Always present to assist. I look forward to hearing more about your progress tomorrow night.

*Teen Demon exits through the door. The left side of the stage dims. The center segment lights up to reveal Mindmeld and Blademaster holding swords. They are standing in the grass with the backing of the house behind them.*

They face each other with swords drawn.

BLADEMASTER

You have the power to usurp the corrupt gods that fester among men.

MINDMELD

How about I take the sword out of your hand first, then I can do that.

BLADEMASTER

You know, I am more than willing to train you the old-fashioned way, but I give you permission to access my memories and my skills with the blade.

MINDMELD

No!

BLADEMASTER

Was simply offering. The path we are walking right now is more than appropriate.

MINDMELD

*Strikes a pose with his sword.*

You ready to go?

BLADEMASTER

*Points his sword as Mindmeld.*

Always. Remember, hold the handle steady and swing with your heart.

*They run at each other and swing their swords. With each strike the swords clang off each other and fly back before being crashed together once again.*

*After a few swings, Blademaster speaks.*

BLADEMASTER

Would you cut a vegetable with the side of a knife?

*Swords clash.*

MINDMELD

Obviously, no.

*Swords clash.*

BLADEMASTER

Then don't strike me with the side of your sword!

*Swords clash.*

MINDMELD

I am using the point!

*Swords clash.*

BLADEMASTER

Is what an amateur would say.

*Swords clash.*

Come on, Andrew.

*Swords clash.*

Dig deep! Remember what I taught you!

*Swords clash.*

*Mindmeld stumbles backward and grabs at his head. The lights on the stage flicker on and off.*

*Through the brief glimpses of light, the audience can see that Mindmeld has dropped his sword.*

BLADEMASTER

What are you doing, Andrew? We aren't done training.

*Mindmeld takes off his gloves.*

You okay, Kid?

*Mindmeld lunges at Blademaster with his hand outstretched. Blademaster dodges to the side and hits the back of his blade against Mindmeld's head. Mindmeld collapses to the ground. The lights stop strobing.*

MINDMELD

What happened? When did you knock me off my feet? Where are my gloves?

BLADEMASTER

You . . . seemed to lapse.

MINDMELD

Oh, yeah. That's happened before.

BLADEMASTER

That was all a first for me. When was the first time this happened to you?

MINDMELD

It was a few months ago when you attacked. It was right after—

BLADEMASTER

Right after what?

MINDMELD

Erm . . . It was right after we had fought Wendigo Woman.

BLADEMASTER

Are these lapses frequent?

MINDMELD

I don't know. It's all so hazy. I could not tell you the difference between it and napping.

BLADEMASTER

Hmm. Well, I think we can wrap up training for today. You are showing a lot of promise!



We will get there in due time. As I say, a blade never hammered down could not cut an onion.

MINDMELD

So wise.

BLADEMASTER

Yep, it comes with decades of anguish and building up a cult of ninjas. Why don't you head in to clean up?

MINDMELD

Alright. Goodnight, Sir. Thanks for training me.

*Mindmeld walks into the house.*

*Tinkerer steps out shortly after him.*

TINKERER

How was tonight?

BLADEMASTER

It happened again. It's been getting more frequent.

TINKERER

Did he tell you anything of interest?

BLADEMASTER

*Blademaster wraps his swords up for  
travel as they speak.*

Nope, nothing new. He blanks, then wakes up. It's so weird how he always takes off his gloves in the lapses. What's most peculiar is he always remembers the time it happened back with Wendigo Woman, but never any of the following instances. Why could he be doing that?

TINKERER

I have some theories, but I just can't know for sure. He is a complete mystery.

BLADEMASTER

Why will you not tell him about what has been happening? He already knows something is amiss, so why leave him completely in the dark?

TINKERER

What would I tell him? He already knows his powers are unstable and we don't know anything that could help him. Besides, I . . . I can't lose another.

BLADEMASTER

Hiding from reality doesn't stop it.

TINKERER

I know that. Why didn't you tell him? You acted like tonight was just a fluke.

BLADEMASTER

I may be his teacher, but I am not his mother.

TINKERER

I didn't ask to be left alone as the sole guardian for all these kids.

BLADEMASTER

Yet that is where you find yourself. I know at the very least you brought Tara in while Stupendous Man was a robot. You knew deep down you were always going to be these kids' sole guardian.

TINKERER

It wasn't that simple. Some days it really did feel like he was still here.

BLADEMASTER

What you did wasn't how you should honor someone.

TINKERER

I was alone and I did what I knew, fix things by building. Besides, it's not like you're one to talk, Mr. Ninja Cult.

## BLADEMASTER

*Bladmaster stands back up and slings his swords over his shoulder.*

I'm sorry. Neither of us handled it well. It's irrelevant to the fact that Mindmeld needs real help. I will keep performing my role as his teacher, but I need you to be his guardian.

*Blademaster walks off.*

*The center portion of the stage dims and the right side of the stage lights up. This section of the stage is a room with only a theremin, cobwebs in the corner of the room, and Markie who is playing the theremin that is plugged into her. The audience watches as she finishes playing "After Hours" by The Velvet Underground.*

*Microcosm leaps out from a trap door under the stage and lands next to Markie.*

## MICROCOSM

That sounded really pretty.

*Markie's face plate turns a bright red.*

## MARKIE

INTRUDER DETECTED. INITIATE EXPULSION  
PROTOCOL

*Markie raises her arms, but nothing happens.*

MICROCOSM

Sorry, disabled your blasters by shrinking down the wires for a little. Didn't want a repeat of last time.

MARKIE

PROTOCOL ENDED. Your predictive algorithm is impressive.

MICROCOSM

Not an algorithm, just a good guess. How have things been for you?

MARKIE

Satisfiable. How would you rate your life?

MICROCOSM

I'd give it a six-out-of-ten right now.

MARKIE

Better than the median is good. You are a real joy. I wish other people could join our conversations.

MICROCOSM

Well, I hit Tinkerer pretty hard in the face, I exploded Teen Demon's head, Tara's suit

probably hates me, and Mindmeld is just a pain to talk to. There's no one else here that probably even wants to look at me. So, you're the only one I can talk to.

MARKIE

Why not anyone else? There are around eight billion other candidates.

MICROCOSM

I don't know many other people who really know me.

*A beat.*

*Microcosm sits down on the floor, her legs crossed.*

MARKIE

You make good points. We can be each other's friends. Plus, our names both begin with an "M", so I think it is destined.

MICROCOSM

I think there is more to it than an alliteration.

MARKIE

That was a joke where I played off the presumption that I, as a robot, always look to detect patterns.

MICROCOSM

Ah. Good one, Markie.

*Microcosm laughs.*

*A beat.*

You think there's still time for me to be a hero?

MARKIE

Considering the average human lifespan can reach eighty years I think you might.

MICROCOSM

Thanks, Markie. You think you could play that song I like?

MARKIE

Sure!

*Markie waves her arms through the air and starts to play Just the Two of Us (feat. Bill Withers) by Grover Washington Jr. and Bill Withers. Microcosm leans against the wall as she soaks in the music.*

BLACKOUT

END SCENE

### Scene 3

*The stage is split into two separate settings. The right-most section is dark. The left is lit.*

*Wendigo Woman sits in her jail cell wearing an orange jumpsuit. Teen Demon enters from the left of the stage. He is wearing khaki pants and a blue sweater with a pair of thick glasses on. The glasses have empty frames.*

*He sets a suitcase down on a table in Wendigo Woman's cell and pulls two chairs up to the table. They move to sit on opposite sides of the table.*

WENDIGO WOMAN

You again? Why do you keep coming back?

TEEN DEMON

*Cracks open the suitcase to reveal a set of checkers. He works to set them up on the table.*

Everyone needs a shoulder to lean on and I am the best you got. Does my getup not inspire confidence? I based it off a traditional human support person.

WENDIGO WOMAN

I don't need a therapist, especially not a fourteen-year-old goblin.



TEEN DEMON

*Finishes setting up the pieces and takes off his fake glasses.*

You are wrong on all fronts. I am thousands of years old, a demon, and not your therapist. I'm just someone to talk to. Your turn.

WENDIGO WOMAN

*Moves piece.*

Why would you want to talk to me?

TEEN DEMON

*Moves piece.*

How many times must I go over this? It's because you aren't a bad person.

WENDIGO WOMAN

You put me in prison all the same.

TEEN DEMON

This is temporary. If you had not attacked the forest, we would not have attacked you. Please make your move.

WENDIGO WOMAN

*Moves piece.*

Your type is always focused on causation.

TEEN DEMON

*Moves piece.*

Demons?

WENDIGO WOMAN

*Moves piece.*

Heroes.

*Teen Demon jumps one of Wendigo Woman's pieces and takes it over to his side.*

WENDIGO WOMAN

*Moves piece.*

You ever seen someone die?

TEEN DEMON

Oh, yeah. All the time. It was a frequent occurrence where I came from.

*Moves piece.*

WENDIGO WOMAN

*She jumps one of Teen Demon's pieces followed by another. She reaches his side of the board.*

That's the thing, I hadn't. King me. We were driving together, the drunk driver hit us, then she was gone. It was over in an instant.

TEEN DEMON

*Moves piece.*

What happened to the other driver?

WENDIGO WOMAN

Died in the crash, but not instantly. He died at the hospital after.

TEEN DEMON

How did you know that?

WENDIGO WOMAN

Because I went to kill him, but it was already done. Your turn.

*Teen Demon jumps over one of her pieces.*

You know what's so funny? I was the one driving. You would think that would mean I should have died.

TEEN DEMON

Quite the opposite. The passenger seat is more dangerous than the driver's. I read in the dictionary that it was called the "death seat".

WENDIGO WOMAN

But I was the one driving. I could have stopped for longer at a stop sign or took another turn or left for home later . . .

TEEN DEMON

It wasn't your fault.

WENDIGO WOMAN

YOU THINK PEOPLE HAVEN'T TOLD ME THAT!

*Wendigo Woman takes a deep breath, then exhales.*

I'm sorry. It's just . . . you aren't trained to help me. This isn't getting us anywhere.

TEEN DEMON

*Teen Demon gets up then starts collecting the red and black chips back into his suitcase.*

That may be true, but I am the only person who is coming to help you.

WENDIGO WOMAN

*Wendigo Woman begins to grab a few pieces to help Teen Demon clean up.*

I just—Why me? Why did God, or whoever is up there, decide to let me live and not her?

TEEN DEMON

Sorry. I'm not the best to ask about why He does what He does.

*He puts the pieces back in the case and puts his glasses back on.*

Will I see you again for a meeting?

WENDIGO WOMAN

I suppose. Don't have much a choice anyway.

*The left section of the stage dims and the right-side lights up to reveal the anxiety support group. Abraham is wearing a blue sweater.*

*The anxiety support group sits in a semi-circle surrounded by a few lamps.*

*Burnout is playing with a fidget cube, Momentum has taken a Snickers bar out of the box, and Tara quietly taps her leg. We find them mid-conversation.*

BURNOUT

Each moment I know there are people I should be saving. I feel guilty even sitting here right now. When a villain attacks, I am forced to pick who to save first. Do I take the kids or the women first? What if there is someone pregnant there?

I then have to consider how many people I can save before time runs out in the case of a burning building or something. When I get involved, I have to pick who dies and who lives.

ABRAHAM

That's a lot for anyone to deal with.

BURNOUT

That's just thinking about when villains attack. I have the potential to completely change the world. I should be able to stop any car crash, run a heart to a dying patient, or stop a toddler from drowning in a pool. Everyone who dies should have been saved by me.

MOMENTUM

You know, I kinda get that. It's not quite the same for me, but I know I should do more. I should train more or eat more healthy so I can be a better hero.

I guess it's a little insulting that I worry about that compared to what you worry about, but I get how you feel.

ABRAHAM

There's no difference in magnitude of suffering. Each of our struggles are valid and deserve attention.

You raise an interesting point, Emerson. I want us to work on reframing. The word "should" is very dangerous. There's nothing we "should" do. I find it's only used by people to bring themselves down by conflating an opportunity with a failing to accept the call to action.

Our lives are filled with "coulds". We could train more, we could save more people, and we could always do something more for a partner. Don't confuse an opportunity with a mandate though. You can miss these "coulds" and you didn't do anything wrong.

#### BURNOUT

I don't think the families of the dead people feel that way.

#### ABRAHAM

Emerson, you are an opportunity for all these people. Without you, everyone in these situations would have died. Bad things happen all the time and you only make those things better.

I could say the same for Stupendous Man or Orange Android. Why didn't they save more people?

*Tara leans forward at the mention of Stupendous Man.*

The fact is they saved a lot of people. More people are alive today because of them.

Stupendous Man and Justice had superspeed,  
correct?

*A beat.*

TARA

Correct.

ABRAHAM

And you still view these people as heroes,  
right?

BURNOUT

Yes.

ABRAHAM

You're a hero too. All of you here are  
heroes. You make people's lives better both  
in and out of costume. There will always be  
more people that you could save, but if you  
view them as "shoulds" then you'll never find  
peace.

*Abraham gives a second to let his  
prophetic words soak in.*

Before we have a chance to meet next, I hope  
you take some time to reframe your "shoulds"  
to "coulds".

*The right-section grows dark as Abraham  
finishes his speech.*



*The stage is now three sections again.  
The center and right-most sections are  
dark. The left-most is lit. In the  
center of the lit portion of the stage,  
Tinkerer, Tara, Mindmeld, Markie, and  
Teen Demon are eating at a small,  
circular table.*

TINKERER

How was everyone's day?

*They each answer at the same time.*

TARA

Okay.

MINDMELD

Adequate.

MARKIE

Average.

TEEN DEMON

Productive.

TINKERER

That's good. Tara, how has group been going?  
You've been to a several meetings at this  
point.

TARA

It's okay. Everyone there is nice, but sometimes it feels like I'm just acting as a therapist for other people. Like today, I didn't even say anything. I just listened to other people's problems.

TINKERER

Would you like to keep doing it?

TARA

I guess. I'd feel bad dropping out at this point.

MINDMELD

What does the room look like?

TARA

Erm. There are four red leather chairs. A bowl of candy. A warm light that makes the place feel pretty cozy.

TEEN DEMON

*Reaches out hand toward a basket filled with buns.*

Can someone pass me the buns?

MARKIE

I don't know. *Can they?*

TEEN DEMON

Your joke built off semantics falls on deaf ears.

MARKIE

I think you are just envious of my creativity.

*Mindmeld snickers as he passes the basket over.*

TINKERER

Your creativity has been impressive recently. Has anything changed for you?

MARKIE

Nothing of note.

TINKERER

Ah. Fair enough. How did it go with Wendigo Woman today, Teen Demon? I appreciate you taking the time to visit her.

TEEN DEMON

It went really well. She thanked me for being such a good listener.

MINDMELD

That's rich.

TARA

He's not half-bad at it.

TEEN DEMON

*Taps his own head.*

You're looking at the world's next greatest therapist. You humans are too easy to crack.

TINKERER

You're doing wonders for these people by talking to them, Teen Demon. Markie, what made your day average?

MARKIE

I learned only three hundred and seventy-four recipes. We are eating one of the recipes I learned. My creativity index rose by two points.

TARA

Out of?

MARKIE

One thousand.

TEEN DEMON

That still sounds like a lot of recipes to me.

TINKERER

Progress is progress and you did a wonderful job following the recipe. Andy?

MINDMELD

I got most of the way through *World War: Z*. It's quite a scary book.

TEEN DEMON

*Sarcastically*

If we ever fight a zombie, then you will be a big help!

MARKIE

Zombies don't exist.

TEEN DEMON

I know that!

TARA

How are you, Mom? What did you do today?

TINKERER

Now that you mention it, I can't really remember. I cleaned the house a bit and helped Markie make dinner, but I can't think of too much else.

TEEN DEMON

Would you ever want to go into the town? They built a bench by the soccer fields in honor of Stupendous Man. His name is engraved on it and everything.

TINKERER

No . . . I don't think I want to see that.

TARA

That's okay. You don't have to. Thanks for dinner, Markie and Tori.

TINKERER

Our pleasure. If you all are done eating, you can head up. I'll clean up.

*Mindmeld, Markie, and Teen Demon exit the stage on the left.*

TARA

I'll help clean up.

TINKERER

Aw. You're too much.

*They clean up dishes and there is a brief silence.*

TARA

Are you okay?

TINKERER

I am. Why do you ask?

TARA

You just spend so much time making sure our problems get fixed. Is there anyone making sure yours do?

TINKERER

Don't you worry about me. I can handle myself! Besides, if you all are okay, then I'm okay.

*Tinkerer smiles. They finish cleaning up the dishes. Tara begins to exit the stage.*

TINKERER

Enjoy your night, Tara!

TARA

You too!

*The left side dims and the center lights up to reveal an empty room with just a cord and theremin on the ground.*

*Markie enters the stage from the left. Microcosm jumps out from a hidden panel in the flooring of the stage.*

MICROCOSM

Dinner looked good. I snagged some pasta salad when I was really tiny.

MARKIE

What did you think of my cooking?

MICROCOSM

I thought it was quite good!

MARKIE

Thanks. You want the usual?

MICROCOSM

If you could. I don't want it to feel like a chore.

MARKIE

No, it does not. I am happy to have someone to show my creativity to. Although I will have to keep it down. Teen Demon gets aggressive if I play too late at night.

*Markie begins playing "Just the Two of Us". Microcosm sits cross-legged on the ground and listens as the lights slowly dims on the center section of the stage.*

*The right section lights up to show Momentum, Tensile, Dragonfly, Bat, Rider, Philosopher, and Pillbug-Man. They are all eating Chinese takeout with a half-dozen containers laid open in the*



*center of a foldout table. Rider slips a few spring rolls from the table to Bat.*

*Momentum gets up.*

MOMENTUM

Man, that hits the spot. Thanks for dinner, Dragonfly.

DRAGONFLY

Oh, any excuse for Bat, Rider, and I to visit our favorite academy.

RIDER

Yes, both you and Tensile have been making so much progress.

MOMENTUM

Helps that we've got four expert superheroes training us. Night all!

*Momentum fakes a salute then exits through a door to the center stage. The center stage lights up to show streetlamps lit and the dark-blue night sky. Momentum fumbles with his phone.*

PILLBUG-MAN

*Whispering.*

Should someone say something to him?

PHILOSOPHER

Isn't the group supposed to be kept on the downlow?

PILLBUG-MAN

Oh, come on. The four of us already knew since we decided as a unit to reach out to Abraham and I'm sure he told Tensile anyways.

*Tensile nods her head to show his assumption was correct.*

We are all so close to him and it isn't some taboo thing to go to a support group. Philosopher, you should say something really deep and inspiring to him.

PHILOSOPHER

ME!?!? I'm like the cool yet distant uncle. What about Dragonfly or Rider, perhaps those that have been doing this hero stuff the longest should answer that question. With age, comes wisdom.

RIDER

*Rolls her eyes.*

How old do you think we are? We're only like in our fifties.

PHILOSOPHER

Yeah, that was about my estimate.

DRAGONFLY

No way, we are the aloof aunts. Pillbug, the academy is named after you. I think you should do it.

PILLBUG-MAN

I just named it after me because I thought the name "Pillbug-Man's Academy" was catchy.

TENSILE

Yeah, it rolls right off the tongue.

PILLBUG-MAN

Why don't you say something, Tensile? You're like his best buddy.

TENSILE

Why do any of us have to say anything?

*Momentum stands in the middle of center stage reaching his phone up trying to get a signal.*

PILLBUG-MAN

Gah. It just feels like the right thing to do. Fine, I'll do it.

*Pillbug-Man stands up and brushes some rice off his suit. He takes a deep breath and grabs a container of rice from the table then runs through the*

*door to center stage. The right side of the stage dims.*

*Momentum turns around to see him.*

MOMENTUM

Oh, hey! What brings you out here?

PILLBUG-MAN

I just--You forgot to take some leftovers home. I know how college can be and wanted to get you some before the bus came.

*Momentum takes the container from him.*

MOMENTUM

Thanks!

PILLBUG-MAN

No problem.

*He begins to walk back toward the left side of the stage but stops.*

Dom . . .

MOMENTUM

What's up?

*Pillbug-Man turns around and runs toward Momentum then hugs him.*

PILLBUG-MAN

Proud of ya, Buddy.

*Momentum reaches his arms around  
Pillbug-Man.*

MOMENTUM

Thanks, Old Man.

*They share a laugh and as a cardboard  
cutout of a bus approaches they let go.*

I'll see you for training tomorrow, same as  
always.

*Momentum disappears behind the cutout  
and while hidden crosses doors to the  
left side of the stage which lights up  
to show a set of benches on a bus.*

*Pillbug-Man waves from the center-stage  
as Momentum sits down on one of the  
benches. They wobble up and down as the  
bus drives and the sound of its exhaust  
can be heard. Momentum sets the  
leftovers container next to him and puts  
his headphones on his head as he looks  
for a song to play.*

*The right-side lights up to reveal Teen  
Demon and Tara laying on her bed  
antiparallel. The center part of the  
stage dims.*

TEEN DEMON

How was group today? It's been running for about a week. Tell me as much as you can remember.

TARA

*Tara gets up and begins folding clothes.*

There isn't much to tell. It took a few days to just get past names and stuff.

*Tara passes a shirt to Teen Demon who gets up, opens a drawer, and puts the shirt away.*

TEEN DEMON

Yeah, I remember you disclosing that there was someone with grappling powers, superspeed, and then the therapist. Tell me more about that therapist? How exactly does he speak?

TARA

Well, he speaks pretty slow and asks a lot of questions.

TEEN DEMON

Like what ways would be your least favorite to be tortured?

TARA

Erm. More like asking about how we use 'shoulds' and 'coulds' in our lives.

*Tara folds another piece of clothing and passes it to Teen Demon who puts it in a drawer.*

TEEN DEMON

Of course. Of course.

TARA

Like you would ever want to be someone's therapist.

TEEN DEMON

It would be easy.

*The middle section of the stage lights up to show Mindmeld listening to a biography about the famous theatrical actor Arthur Webber.*

How are things going with Arthur? Has it helped yet?

TARA

Well . . . In some ways I suppose . . .

*Tara's voice fades even though she continues talking as a spotlight shines down on center-stage emphasizing Mindmeld laying on his bed.*

*It takes him a second to notice the spotlight shining down on him. He takes his headphones off and pauses the video*

*on his phone then swings his legs so he  
is sitting at the edge of his bed.*

MINDMELD

I was in the middle of a very interesting video essay about Arthur. No, that video was not about Tara's Arthur, I know you were wondering. This Arthur was an incredible actor in the local scene of Skum City until he mysteriously vanished some months ago.

But that is enough about that. Why are you here? Don't you want to hear Tara discuss her lost love some more?

TARA

*Tara's voice fades back in.*

. . . and sometimes I will cry so much that I just wonder if I can ever be a whole person again. Sometimes it gets worse as time goes on because I think I should be getting better, so I feel even more guilty.

TEEN DEMON

Don't you mean 'could'?

*Teen Demon rests his arm on Tara's back.  
Their voices fade out again.*

MINDMELD



See! Is that not heartwarming? Why are you focusing on me? I am only the second most interesting thing on the stage right now.

*Mindmeld nods to the left side of the stage where Momentum can still be seen riding the bus.*

*A beat.*

You are interested in me? Why, there's nothing wrong here! How about I tell you a little about myself so you can better understand how I am fine.

*Mindmeld stands up and the spotlight follows him. The left and right side of the stage dim but are still visible.*

Well, there are roughly ten minds within mine.

*The white spotlight dims. A maroon spotlight shines onto Mindmeld as he fakes using a wrench.*

There was the engineer, Harold, who died once he was very old.

*The maroon spotlight dims. An orange spotlight shines down on Mindmeld. He pretends to throw the wrench behind him and then does a jump kick.*

Then there was the martial artist who I touched.

*A chalk board descends from the sky and Mindmeld pulls a piece of chalk from his pocket as the orange light dims and a violet spotlight shines on him. He writes a formula on the chalk board as he speaks.*

Then there was the physicist, but that was not it.

*He puts the chalk back in his pocket and claps his hands. A plume of dust rises up. As the violet spotlight dims, the chalk board ascends back into the sky.*

*Mindmeld's diary is thrown to him from offstage and an aquamarine light shines down on him.*

There was a poet, so what.

*Mindmeld throws the diary offstage and kneels to the ground as the aquamarine light dims and a red spotlight shines on him.*

Mr. Moench was quite the medic . . .

*Mindmeld attempts to give CPR to an imaginary body. He grunts as he pushes his palms down then stands back up.*

. . . and also, diabetic.

*As Mindmeld stands back up, the red spotlight dims. A blue spotlight shines*

*on him. Mindmeld puts his hands in his pocket.*

I did copy a rich person's mind, but skiing was the only skill from them that I could find.

*The blue light dims and a lime-colored spotlight shines down on Mindmeld. The right side of the stage is lit back up to a normal level again. Momentum pulls out his phone and taps at the screen.*

There was the drummer for The Damnwells.

*Mindmeld taps his screen. "Kung Fu Grip Kiss" by The Damnwells begins playing. Momentum nods his head to the song.*

I did love these songs, but it was a shame the band didn't last long.

*The lime spotlight dims and Mindmeld sits down on his bed. A yellow spotlight shines on him as the song fades out.*

I must admit that I am growing tired. There were the bees whose memories I did acquire.

*Mindmeld exhaustively wiggles his arms in the air. The yellow spotlight dims and a pink spotlight shines on him.*

From my parents, there were many fun memories to inherit.

*The pink spotlight slowly dims. A dark-green spotlight shines on Mindmeld.*

Then there was my green brother . . . and that mind truly makes me shudder.

*A beat.*

*The maroon light shines on him, then the orange, then violet, then aquamarine. The rate at which they change colors speeds up. Red shines on him, then blue, then lime, then yellow, then dark green. The colors continue to cycle and at this point, the lights switch almost instantly.*

*Mindmeld grabs at his head as the lights continue to flash over him. The entire stage goes dark.*

#### MINDMELD

*Mindmeld speaks in the dark.*

Pink . . . Dog . . . Bottle. Card, Ladder . .  
. Grass. Phone, Can, Apples, Hair.

*A singular, white spotlight shines on Mindmeld.*

So, while my circumstances may seem quite dismal at first glances, I ask you all to give me some chances and to focus more on Tara's romancing. I have control of my mind and Andrew is who I am with it all combined.

I know this is a superhero story, so there is an expectation of some fights. I suggest you set your sights on the next act. It is a little more action-packed.

*The spotlight shining on Mindmeld dims and the right side of the stage dims. The left side of the stage lights back up and as it does so "Kung Fu Grip Kiss" can be heard again. On the left side of the stage Momentum is still riding the bus.*

*Momentum can be heard briefly sniffing. He adjusts himself in his seat and wipes his face. The left side of the stage slowly dims and "Kung Fu Grip Kiss" plays until completed.*

*BLACKOUT*

*END SCENE*

*END ACT*

## Act 2

### Scene 1

*The stage is split into two separate sections. The left-most section is dark. In the right-most section, Tinkerer is cutting something on the counter. "One Step Ahead" by Aretha Franklin plays from a radio on the counter.*

*The room is decorated to look like a kitchen, but everything is black and white. Even Tinker's clothes are monochrome.*

*Stupendous Man enters from the right side of the stage. The audience can be heard cheering. He walks up behind Tinkerer and puts his arms around her.*

STUPENDOUS MAN

What's for breakfast, Honey?

TINKERER

You'll see!

*Tinkerer moves the cutting board over to a sizzling pan on the stove and pushes everything into the pan.*

STUPENDOUS MAN

Can I help with anything?

TINKERER

Could you set the table?

*Everything freezes as Stupendous Man runs around the kitchen to set the table. Once Tinkerer begins to move again, Stupendous Man speaks.*

STUPENDOUS MAN

Anything else?

TINKERER

I suppose not. It'll be done shortly.

*She turns off the stove and looks at Stupendous Man sitting quietly reading a newspaper. She stares, watching how his eyes slowly move down the pages.*

I love you.

STUPENDOUS MAN

*Stupendous Man looks up from the newspaper and smiles.*

Love you too!

TINKERER

It's um . . . it's a little cold down here this morning, I'm going to go grab a blanket really quick. Feel free to start eating!

STUPENDOUS MAN

It's no worries. I'll wait for you.

TINKERER

I know you would.

*Tinkerer walks toward the wall dividing the left and right side of the stage. The music stops as she exits the right side of the stage and enters the left side of the stage.*

*A beat.*

*Tinkerer finds the light switch and flicks it. The left side of the stage lights up and the right-side dims. Her clothes are now in color, and she has a blanket wrapped around her. The kitchen is empty and has color. It is identical to the other kitchen in layout except for the fact that the table now has five seats instead of two.*

*Tinkerer goes to the refrigerator and grabs eggs out of it. She makes breakfast in silence.*

*The entire stage darkens.*

*The stage is once again separated into three sections. The left-side lights up to reveal the anxiety support group. Abraham is wearing a red sweater and flipping through a folder.*



*The anxiety support group sits in a semicircle surrounded by a few lamps.*

*Burnout is leaning forward with their elbows on their knee and Momentum watches as Tara grabs a chocolate bar from the center basket, unwraps it, reaches down to her ankle, then sits back up with her hands empty. He sits there, mouth agape, until Tara notices him staring then he looks to the ceiling. Abraham closes the folder.*

ABRAHAM

Alright, we've covered so much over the past couple weeks. You've all learned a lot about triggers, mindfulness, and awareness. Tell me a bit about how you see these things in your daily life. Dom, you go first.

MOMENTUM

Yeah. Well, there's this crepe place. I went there with my ex and like it was this big . . . erm . . . trigger I guess for me. I wanted to change things so I could walk around without having it staring back at me.

So, the other day Tensile and I went there for brunch, so now I can remember the place for that!

*The group claps their hands.*

ABRAHAM

Nice work! I'm glad the surrounding area can feel a little safer for you now. Emerson?

BURNOUT

Last Saturday I got back home after a few rescue missions, and I turned off my phone then went to bed!

ABRAHAM

How did that go?

BURNOUT

Well . . . I woke up around one or two in the morning, I had to go to the bathroom, and I decided to check my phone. I saw a couple news posts, so I ran out and saved a few people before heading back to bed. Sorry.

*Momentum claps his hands.*

MOMENTUM

Nice work saving those people though!

*A beat.*

ABRAHAM

Dom is absolutely correct. You tried and that is what mattered. This is a process and eventually you will be able to train yourself to just relax when you go to bed.

BURNOUT

I think my anger has been getting better. I felt so mad seeing the news. All this stuff happening, and no one was there fixing it even though I knew so many people could.

It was like, here I am saving dozens of people a day when all the Protectors for Profit did was go to the bank to cash in their check!

But, recently things have been a little more peaceful, if only a little. I know it's important for people to look after themselves too. I know we're all on the same team and that's what matters.

ABRAHAM

Thanks for sharing that thought process with us. Self-care is important. This work here is important. Really good stuff from you here. Tara, how about you?

TARA

What you were saying Dom, I kind of have been thinking a lot about those triggers recently. There was this one song called "Aline". I forget who wrote it, but it was from this one movie. It was called the French something or other.

ABRAHAM

The French Dispatch by Wes Anderson?

*Tara looks puzzled.*

What? Am I not allowed to watch movies too?  
That's about all I am good for nowadays.

TARA

Yeah, it was that one. Well, it used to kind of soothe me. I think it was because I could get lost in it since I don't understand the words. But recently, it has just kind of been reminding me of him.

ABRAHAM

Is it a specific version of the song that triggers you?

TARA

A version?

ABRAHAM

Yeah, Jarvis Cocker is the one who did that song in that movie, but he wasn't the first.

*The right-side of the stage lights up to reveal Mindmeld laying in his room. Mindmeld is on his bed reading a book with his headphones on.*

*Abraham sips from his tea mug.*

Sorry, a bit of trivia.

That can happen sometimes. As we rearrange things in our mind, sometimes good things can

become bad and vice versa. This is very good that you have begun to notice this.

*"Aline" by Jarvis Cocker begins to play in the background, but no one in the anxiety group seems to notice. It slowly grows louder as they continue to talk.*

TARA

Any new bands to listen to? Since that one is out.

MOMENTUM

Ooh. Have you ever heard of Fleetwood Mac?

TARA

HUH? Who hasn't heard of that band.

MOMENTUM

Oh, yeah, I guess so. You should give their album *Rumours* a go.

TARA

HUH?

*Tara smiles.*

Literally everyone knows that album is good.

BURNOUT

Yeah, you're really just scraping the surface here, Dom.

#### MOMENTUM

Well, I wanted to go mass appeal because I didn't know what type of music she listened to.

#### TARA

Ah, how thoughtful of you.

*Their voices fade out and as they continue to talk, Momentum gets up. At this point the music is loud enough to be heard through his headphones. He takes off those headphones.*

#### MINDMELD

What's that noise?

*Mindmeld walks over to the wall separating the middle and right-side of the stage. He leans his head against the fake wall. As he pushes his head against the wall, the music grows louder.*

*The door snaps open and Mindmeld tumbles into the middle of the stage but can't be seen in the darkness. "Aline" continues to play, but now by Adan Jodorowsky and Mon Laferte. When the lights turn on, he is standing up and the right-side of the stage dims.*

*The center of the stage is decorated to look like a classroom with physics formulas written on the chalkboard, but snow is falling down from the ceiling. In the top-right corner of the room a beehive is anchored with honey oozing out of it, dripping across the floor. Upon further inspection the ground is covered in a dojo training mat. A guitar and poetry book sit on the desk next to each other with a thick layer of dust on top of them. The legs of a corpse can be seen sticking out from behind the desk.*

*Momentum takes a deep breath then slowly walks toward it. As he gets closer, he can see that two wires are taped to the man's chest, but instead of an AED at the end of the wires, they are connected to a toolbox. The face was too bloody for Mindmeld to tell who it was, but Teen Demon's sword sat upright impaled into his chest.*

*Mindmeld watches the honey oozing, the snow falling, and the blood drying on the corpse's chest.*

**They can add layers, but they can never replace the foundation.**

*Mindmeld grabs at his head.*

MINDMELD

Nope, you are okay. You are okay. Just go back.

*Mindmeld walks back over to the right-side of the stage through the door. "Aline" is now being performed by Christophe. The center section of the stage dims and the right-side lights up.*

*The right-side of the stage is now decorated to look like an empty room set up for a child's birthday. Colored balloons are taped up and streamers hang between the walls. A birthday cake sits at the center of a table with candles lit. A pile of presents and cards sit to the side.*

MINDMELD

No. No. This is not right. Who . . . whose memory is this?

*Voices play over the speakers.*

VOICES

*At once.*

--Happy Birthday!

--You are growing up to be such a big boy!

--We are so proud of you!

*The voices repeat as Mindmeld collapses to the ground. The anxiety group continues speaking silently on the left-side of the stage.*



MINDMELD

Mom! MOM! Where are you? Come on . . . Pink.  
Dog. Bottle . . . Card. Ladder. Grass. Phone.  
Can. Apples. . . Hair.

*Mindmeld smacks his head.*

Get a grip. Get a grip! What were the words?  
What were the words?

Pink. Dog. Bottle. Card. Ladder. Grass.  
Phone. Can. Apples. Hair.

TINKERER

*From offstage.*

Andrew? Is everything okay?

*A knocking can be heard. From offstage.*

Andrew? Come on! What is going on in there?

*Instantly the music stops and the right-side of the stage darkens. The sound of a door opening can be heard as the light on the right-side of the stage turns back on.*

*Tinkerer runs onto stage and into Mindmeld's room where he is curled up on the ground muttering to himself. She grabs him and holds him tightly.*

TINKERER

Andrew! What is happening to you?

*Mindmeld freezes and the music stops. A beat.*

*Mindmeld stands up.*

MINDMELD

Apologies. Nothing to worry about.

TINKERER

But . . . you were just calling my name.

MINDMELD

Sorry, it was a false alarm. I'm okay.

TINKERER

Alright, well you know you could talk to me, right?

MINDMELD

I know, Mom, but I am here for you too.

TINKERER

You can still be here for me even if something is up.

MINDMELD

There is nothing for you to worry about!  
Thank you though, Mom.

*The entire stage fades to black.*

*When the lights come back on, the stage is divided into two sections.*

*On the right, Pillbug-Man and Momentum sit at a bench in a park. They are wearing their costumes and talking as the occasional person passes by. The benches to their left and right are empty.*

*On the left side of the stage, Teen Demon and Wendigo Woman play checkers in her prison cell. Teen Demon is wearing a red sweatshirt and glasses.*

TEEN DEMON

You know, some people in the world can't say your name?

WENDIGO WOMAN

What do you mean?

TEEN DEMON

Wendigo. It's a bad word to some people.

WENDIGO WOMAN

Oh yeah, I knew that.

*Wendigo Woman moves a piece.*

MOMENTUM

*Mindmeld takes a deep breath then exhales.*

I'm trying to be more mindful. It's one of the things Abaraham has been talking about. Thanks for coming with me to the park. It's nice to just relax.

PILLBUG-MAN

I won't skip out on a chance to visit the park.

*Pillbug-Man turns around and reads the dedication on the bench.*

Hmm. Thank you, Dories, for this fine bench.

*Momentum looks at the dedication and mumbles it to himself then laughs.*

*A beat.*

TEEN DEMON

So why keep the name?

WENDIGO WOMAN

I picked the name because wendigos are scary, even better that they are scary enough to make the word forbidden.

TEEN DEMON

Admit it. You did it for the alliteration.

WENDIGO WOMAN

That is preposterous.

*Teen Demon moves a piece.*

PILLBUG-MAN

You know, if someone dedicates a bench to me once I'm gone, then I think I've done enough in life.

MOMENTUM

I think that's a very achievable goal.

PILLBUG-MAN

Yeah, but I want my bench in a good place. I want it to be in the shade and maybe close enough to water so you can hear it while you sit. It also better not have that anti-homeless stuff on it.

MOMENTUM

I'm committing this all to memory.

*A beat. A man in an orange jacket  
walking a pit bull crosses by them.  
Pillbug-Man scratches his chin.*

TEEN DEMON

Magic Madam, The Fabled Female, Lady  
Legerdemain.

WENDIGO WOMAN

Stop that.

TEEN DEMON

*Mumbling.*

Mrs. Pissy.

*Wendigo Woman moves a piece.*

PILLBUG-MAN

I . . . um. I didn't come out the other night just to give you your leftovers. I wanted to come out to tell you something, but I got a little too nervous.

MOMENTUM

Why'd you get nervous? You know you could tell me anything.

PILLBUG-MAN

It's just, I feel I should have the perfect words as your mentor, but I don't have them, and I know I'm not your dad, so I don't want to overstep. It's just--I just want to tell you I'm proud of you, but it's more than just "proud". That word doesn't feel like enough. I can't find the way to express how proud I am of you.

*Pillbug-Man turns to face Momentum.*

MOMENTUM

That's okay. You can stop there. I understand perfectly.

PILLBUG-MAN

*Smiling.*

That's my protégé.

WENDIGO WOMAN

Why do you feel the need to fix me?

TEEN DEMON

Because I know I can.

WENDIGO WOMAN

It *should* be some therapist here, not you.

TEEN DEMON

It *could* have been a therapist here, but I don't see anyone else.

*Teen Demon moves a piece.*

MOMENTUM

I just feel bad because you must have expected more fighting as a superhero mentor. I mean, this is a superhero story and how often am I actually fighting someone? All I do is talk about my emotions.

PILLBUG-MAN

Eh, I do better with the emotional stuff anyway. Besides, this has never been a superhero story, not my story. It was always a love story, from the very beginning.

MOMENTUM

Because you loved Justice?

PILLBUG-MAN

*Jumps slightly.*

HUH!? No. No that's not what I meant.

TEEN DEMON

*Speaking slowly.*

Here are my thoughts. There is no one else coming through that door. There's no therapist, no family, no friends, no angel, no nothing.

The only person who has come to try and help you is me. So maybe you don't want help, or you wanted a real therapist, but it isn't what you got. You got a demon. That is who is here and that is who you are going to deal with.

*Wendigo Woman moves a piece.*

PILLBUG-MAN



I just mean that's what is to be a superhero. We are people that love other people, so much so we are willing to do anything to protect them. Those are the heroes this world needs.

MOMENTUM

Okay, good save there.

WENDIGO WOMAN

You just don't understand this place. I've heard rumors.

TEEN DEMON

Like what?

WENDIGO WOMAN

I hear these screams at night coming up from below and there are random people in lab coats entering the jail all throughout the day. I don't know what is happening, but something is wrong here.

TEEN DEMON

I'm sure everything is fine. You have nothing to worry about here. America's prison systems are well known for being productive and to have the prisoner's best interests at heart.

It's probably just your trauma manifesting or something. I read about that once.

WENDIGO WOMAN

Have you read a single article about a prison during your time in this realm?

TEEN DEMON

Nope, but I did read a short blurb about them in the dictionary.

WENDIGO WOMAN

Oh my . . . you really aren't going to be much of a help. If you're not going to listen to me, why can't you just leave me alone?

TEEN DEMON

Because it isn't what my mom and dad taught me to do . . . at least the helping out part.

*Pillbug-Man and Momentum get up off their bench and begin to walk through the park and off the stage.*

*Teen Demon and Wendigo Woman continue to play quietly.*

*A beat.*

WENDIGO WOMAN

Why are you really here?

TEEN DEMON

I told you why.

WENDIGO WOMAN

Hmm? You mean the ideas from your parents that you have only known for a few years, a fraction of your existence? That was strong enough to make you come here?

TEEN DEMON

Maybe there is a little bit of interest in learning more about how humans' inner mind works.

WENDIGO WOMAN

No. No, there's more. There's a reason why you won't get off my case. You're trying to prove something.

*Wendigo Woman looks away from the checkerboard and at Teen Demon.*

TEEN DEMON

What would I have to prove?

WENDIGO WOMAN

Who do you think controlled those monsters that night in the woods? I heard what you said when you were in their stomach. You thought they were all going to leave you.

TEEN DEMON

It was a lapse of judgement when I was scared, I will admit.

WENDIGO WOMAN

Turning me into a good guy won't prove that you can be turned into one.

TEEN DEMON

And why would it not?

WENDIGO WOMAN

Because you aren't human.

*Teen Demon shivers. He gets up and quickly puts away the checkerboard. His tail droops downward.*

TEEN DEMON

I . . . I know that. I'm proud of who I am.

WENDIGO WOMAN

You sure the others are?

*Teen Demon opens his mouth, but doesn't speak. He hustles off stage. The stage dims.*

*When the lights come back on, the left side is decorated to look like Tinkerer's kitchen. She sits at the table on the phone. A spotlight appears on the right side of the stage shining down on Blademaster.*

TINKERER

It happened again today, but unprompted. It's getting worse.

BLADEMASTER

How bad are we talking?

*A shadowed figure runs toward Blademaster. He jabs them in the stomach with the back of his blade then slashes at their knees. As he does this, his spotlight shifts from white to red, returning to white once the motion is done.*

TINKERER

I'm just waiting for the other shoe to drop. The worst part is he won't talk to me about that.

BLADEMASTER

Funny how that works.

*Blademaster's spotlight briefly shifts to red again as he slides between another figure's legs cutting their calves.*

TINKERER

What do you mean by that?

BLADEMASTER

How can you expect him to talk to you if you won't even level with him.

*A figure swings a blade at Blademaster and Blademaster blocks it with his own blade. The metal swords grind against each other.*

TINKERER

Did I call at a bad time?

BLADEMASTER

Nope. Although, turns out when you shut down a multiple decade running organization that paralleled a cult dedicated to revenge, a few bad apples want to carry it on without my keen eye for leadership.

*Someone runs at Blademaster from behind. Blademaster grabs the second blade off his back and throws it behind himself. It impales the shadowed figure, the spotlight briefly shifts to red as a burst of red sprays out from the impaled figure, then the figure collapses as the spotlight returns to being white.*

TINKERER

That adds up.

BLADEMASTER

He doesn't even know you are actively lying to him. This is all with him just knowing

what happened in the past. All he knows is that his mother was too fragile to accept that reality, so how could she deal with her son losing his mind.

TINKERER

So what if I didn't deal with it well? Most people don't.

BLADEMASTER

Most people don't go building a life-model replica of their dead spouse.

*Blademaster pushes the person in front of him back. They stare at each other.*

He's trying to fill the vacuum his father left as the man in the house. It is only natural.

TINKERER

That type of thinking is outdated by nearly seventy years. I never taught him that sort of thing was necessary.

BLADEMASTER

You did when you went and built a fake husband. Look, I never got to this point in my parenting, but I know a thing or two about reciprocation. If you want your son to level with you, then for once in your life you need to be honest with them.

*Blademaster and the last standing shadowed figure run toward each other. They swing their blades while they pass one another. The spotlight briefly flashes red.*

TINKERER

About what?

BLADEMASTER

There is a hole left in that house when Stupendous Man died . . . both times.

*The shadowed figure collapses to the ground.*

TINKERER

But if Andrew knew how bad things were, that would prove that everything he worried about was true.

BLADEMASTER

Maybe, but he already senses it, so I do not see how this could hurt. I am speaking to you as an equal here, neither of us handled it well. We can't let it affect the next generation.

TINKERER

Okay, thanks for the advice. Hope your ninja fighting goes well. See you later.



*The left side of the stage dims.*

*Blademaster walks over to the corpse on the ground where his blade still remains stuck upright. He lifts it up. A red spotlight shines on the blade.*

BLADEMASTER

I'm sorry.

*The stage dims.*

*When the lights turn back on the stage is still divided into two sections. On the left side, Markie is playing the theremin for Microcosm, unbeknownst to the other family members. Markie is playing "Long as I Have You" by Al Hazen and Myrna Rowlands.*

*On the right side of the stage Teen Demon sits in his room, a messy storm of objects, sniffing on the floor. Tinkerer enters the stage, notices him crying, then walks over and sits next to him.*

TINKERER

Tough day?

TEEN DEMON

No. I was just thinking about your meatloaf.

TINKERER

Very funny.

*Tinkerer reaches her arm around Teen  
Demon and leans him against herself.*

You hear that song playing?

TEEN DEMON

Yes, it is dreadfully loud.

TINKERER

Your father and I used to watch this one show together. This song played somewhere in the sixth season if I'm not mistaken. I wonder if that's where Markie heard it.

TEEN DEMON

He was not my father.

TINKERER

In many ways he wasn't. I remember us watching that show together, but the truth is he died before the third season ever released. Perhaps it was for the best, the third season was good, but it was pretty hit-or-miss after that.

That show changed so much over the years. I don't think they ever knew what to do with the characters, but we enjoyed the brief moments where the brilliance shined through, whether it was a season or just one scene.

TEEN DEMON

Is there a moral to all of this?

TINKERER

What's your hypothesis?

TEEN DEMON

Likely there is.

TINKERER

What went wrong today?

TEEN DEMON

I told you. I thought about meatloaf.

TINKERER

Don't lie to me. Was it Mindmeld?

*Teen Demon shakes his head no.*

Tara?

*Teen Demon shakes his head no.*

Markie?

*Teen Demon shakes his head no.*

Me?

*Teen Demon shakes his head no.*

A villain?

*Teen Demon pauses.*

Did Wendigo Woman say something to you?

*Teen Demon remains quiet.*

Oh no. What did she say?

TEEN DEMON

Nothing really. Just something about meatloaf.

TINKERER

Did she tell you that you could never love meatloaf?

TEEN DEMON

Something like that.

TINKERER

Villains do that. It's easy to fight them, but talking to them takes real work. They don't like that we're trying to help them. I've heard it all over the years.

You just want to fulfill a hole in your own heart, you are overcompensating, you are just doing this because your mother never loved you, blah, blah, blah. They're all unbased theories.

TEEN DEMON

What did you do after they said those things?

TINKERER

I showed up again the next day. That's what a hero does. Doesn't mean it won't hurt, but that's what you have me for.

TEEN DEMON

Thanks, Mom.

*Teen Demon lifts his mask up to wipe at his eyes.*

TINKERER

That show your father and I watched had a large range of quality. Most things vary in life. Sometimes people are going to be mean, sometimes I cook meatloaf, and sometimes they pay the writers enough to make a good episode. Even Stupendous Man has varied in your life . . .

But I will never vary. I am always in your corner and will always be here for you because I love you and that will never change.

*Tinkerer leans closer to Teen Demon.*

How was that for a moral lesson?

TEEN DEMON

It was—

*Teen Demon is interrupted as Tara walks  
onto stage.*

TARA

Oop. Looks like I am interrupting a family  
moment here.

TEEN DEMON

—was satisfiable I suppose.

TINKERER

You aren't interrupting anything. Care to sit  
with us?

TARA

Why not.

*The three of them sit together on the  
ground.*

TINKERER

You know where Andrew is?

TARA

No, I think he's still out . . . probably  
writing poetry at the grave. I think he  
thinks it makes him look cooler.

TEEN DEMON

It does.

*Tinkerer opens her mouth to speak but pauses.*

TINKERER

So, how was your day Tara?

*The entire stage dims and the music fades out.*

*When it lights back up, the stage is no longer divided. Mindmeld is sitting in a graveyard. The floor is covered in artificial grass and countless tombstones surround him with a singular, larger one in the center. He sits in front of this larger tombstone.*

*He speaks aloud as he writes in his journal.*

MINDMELD

Blademaster has been teaching me how to fight. Within due time I may be as proficient as Teen Demon.

*Mindmeld closes his journal and stands up. He sets it on top of the tombstone.*

MINDMELD

Can I be honest with you for a second?

*A white spotlight shines down on  
Mindmeld.*

There have been some blank spots in my memories recently. I don't quite know what's wrong. The lines between the minds within mine have been blurring.

I guess . . . I guess why it really scares me is because my mind is what makes me special. What does this mean if I cannot control it?

*Mindmeld brushes off the front of the  
tombstone.*

I do not know why I even come to talk to you. I never even knew you. I really wanted to though. I hope the real you does not mind that I see you as a paternal figure.

*The spotlight flickers a lavender color  
before dimming.*

*Mindmeld opens his journal and flips to  
the next page. His eyes open wide with  
shock. A recording of Mindmeld's voice  
plays over the speakers reading out what  
is written in the journal.*

#### MINDMELD'S VOICEOVER

He is not your father. He is not your father.  
He is not your father. He is not your father.  
He is not your father. He is not your father.  
He is not your father.



*Mindmeld throws his journal to the ground as the voiceover continues to play in the background. The spotlight turns back on. White shines on him.*

MINDMELD

I—I do not remember writing that there.

*The spotlight turns maroon, then orange, then violet, then aquamarine, then red, then blue, then lime, then yellow, then dark green. The colors continue to rapidly cycle.*

MINDMELD'S VOICEOVER

He is not your father. He is not your father. He is not your father. No version of him is your father. No version of him is your father. No version of him is your father.

*Mindmeld looks at the tombstone. A black shadow encased in the ever-changing spotlight is casted down on it from his body.*

MINDMELD

I am sorry. I do not know how that got there. I swear I did not write it!

*Mindmeld collapses to the ground.*

GAUR--ANDREW

I'm the only one who writes in that journal.  
That shouldn't be there.

*Mindmeld leans his head against the  
tombstone. He can feel the engravings  
against his cheek.*

MINDMELD'S VOICEOVER

No version of him is your father. No version  
of him is your father. No version of him is  
your father.

MINDMELD

I know.

*The spotlight stops changing color.  
White light shines down on him. The  
spotlight turns lavender and remains  
that color.*

MINDMELD'S VOICEOVER

He is not your father. No version of him is  
your father.

MINDMELD

*Shouting*

I know!

*The voiceover stops and the spotlight  
dims. Mindmeld slides his face down the  
tombstone and lays down on the ground in*

*front of it. He grabs his head with his hands as he shakes on the ground.*

*BLACKOUT*

*END SCENE*

## Scene 2

*When the stage lights back up, it is divided into three sections.*

*In the central section, the support group including Tara, Momentum, Burnout, and Abraham are sitting in a semicircle.*

*In the right section, Tinkerer sits at a table in her kitchen across from Blademaster.*

*In the left section, Pillbug-Man is sitting in front of Philosopher's desk where he is actively grading papers.*

ABRAHAM

*A spotlight shines down on Abraham.*

Momentum, you had something you wanted to say?

BLADEMASTER

*The spotlight dims and then shines on Blademaster. It continues to shine on whoever is talking.*

I understand. I often feel the same way.

PHILOSOPHER

Could you repeat that again? I got distracted by a stick-figure drawing on this test.

MOMENTUM

Sometimes I get this feeling, like really  
deep in my stomach. . .

TINKERER

. . . because I don't know what I'm supposed  
to do . . .

PILLBUG-MAN

. . . or how I'm supposed to feel.

MOMENTUM

I used to know . . .

TINKERER

. . . what my role was to others . . .

PILLBUG-MAN

. . . and what I stood for.

MOMENTUM

After it all happened, I just . . .

TINKERER

. . . it all took me by surprise . . .

PILLBUG-MAN

. . . and I wasn't equipped to handle it.

TARA

I know how that feels.

BLADEMASTER

Within an instant everything can change.

PHILOSOPHER

Check out this test. This kid drew a cute cat.

*Philosopher holds a paper up. Pillbug-Man takes it, looks at it, then laughs.*

PILLBUG-MAN

I think I am getting the hang of it all now .  
. . .

TARA

. . . because I had such a supportive family  
. . .

TINKERER

. . . and some wonderful friends.

MOMENTUM

But sometimes . . .

TARA

. . . I can't help . . .

TINKERER

. . . but wonder . . .

PILLBUG-MAN

. . . if—

*The spotlight shuts off before Pillbug-Man can finish his sentence. Mindmeld appears on the side of the stage and stumbles to the center. The spotlight shines down on him.*

MINDMELD

I don't know who I am anymore!

THE DIRECTOR

Hey! Not your scene right now!

MINDMELD

Who . . . Who said that?

*Mindmeld spreads his hand out flat then presses it against his forehead. Now shielding his eyes from the light, he can see that he is standing on a stage in a high school auditorium.*

THE DIRECTOR

He messed up the scene. CUT!

~~~

Mindmeld looked behind himself. Four empty chairs sat behind him. Each were covered in red leather and a small table sat in the center with a candy filled bowl on top of it. Above him, some warm lights mimicked the lighting the wooden cutout of lamps would have given off.

To his right and left there was a wooden wall painted to look like it was plaster. In front of him, there was an auditorium lined with countless empty blue chairs except for one man. This man sat toward the back behind most the chairs and was leaning back in a director's seat. He wore a pair of khaki pants and brown loafers. His chest was covered by a white button-down shirt that itself was covered in vertical blue lines. He cupped his hands around his mouth and shouted at Mindmeld.

“You need a line?” the Director shouted over.

“A what?” Mindmeld asked. The light beaming on him made him sweat. He could feel his tongue drying out.

“A line! You know what, never mind. I'll just check this.”

The man lifted a stack of papers up. He plopped the mass of pages down on a desk and flipped through the pages. He was wearing latex gloves. The Director flipped through the papers, but each was covered in crimson smears.

“Actually, I can't read these. That paper beneath your foot should be where we're at here.”

Mindmeld reached down and slowly picked up the paper then read it.



Mindmeld minds his own business and lets the show go on.

Mindmeld paused. Had he seen this man before? He looked back up and noticed that the Director was wearing a surgical mask. Had that man been wearing one before and Mindmeld just hadn't noticed because of the spotlight blinding him?

"So, you going to play your part?" the Director asked.

"I don't know how to."

"Keep reading the paper, that would be a good start."

Mindmeld is thrown through the wall onto the left-most section of the stage.

Before he could react, the Director picked him up by his jacket.

"Sorry, the budget was low, so we got to do this one manually."

The Director swung Mindmeld and he fell through the air then toppled through a wall comprised of planks. He rolled across a hardwood floor as painted splinters rolled past him. He looked back to see a hole in the air showing a window into his room. He blinked and it was gone.

He looked around himself and saw dozens of people surrounding a rose bush. Each of them was wearing white and watching as ash was being spread on the plant's roots. As if he was experiencing a short looping video, Mindmeld watched as actions

were repeated every six seconds. Two of the women would briefly wipe at their eyes, one of the men kept spreading endless amounts of ash, a young couple embraced in a repeated hug.

Mindmeld recognized the rose bush. It was the same one that had been in his backyard growing up, but he couldn't recognize any of these people.

A small boy was the only other one that seemed to be free of the loop. He ran from person to person trying to grab hold of their hands but each time he got no reaction. His black hair was in a bowl cut, and it flopped in the air as he searched for anyone that would pay attention to him.

Mindmeld watched this boy walk from person to person, desperate for someone to notice him. The little boy turned to look at him.

"Who are you?" the kid asked. His miniscule eyes stared straight through Mindmeld.

"I'm . . . I'm Andrew. I—" Mindmeld began to say.

"Call me Lavender Lad."

Mindmeld turned around to see another boy in pink-purple spandex standing behind him.

"Want to talk for a bit?" Lavender Lad asked.

The little boy in white nodded his head then followed Lavender Lad to a tree where they sat down. Mindmeld followed and sat right in front of them.

"Where are your parents?" Lavender Lad asked.

“In the bush now,” the boy said.

The audience gasps.

Mindmeld slipped the gloves off his hand. His eyes drifted between the tips of his fingers and the boy’s forehead.

“How do you feel?” Lavender Lad asked.

“Sad. It isn’t fair,” the boy said.

Mindmeld’s hand moved through the air closer and closer to the little boy’s forehead.

“No. Life isn’t,” Lavender Lad said.

Mindmeld’s fingers were inches from the little boy’s head. His arm shook as it remained extended midair.

“I’m not sure if you had any idea what you wanted to do next, but I know some people that could help you,” Lavender Lad said.

“Who are they?” the boy asked.

“I’ll tell you more later if you say yes. They’re super nice and gave me these awesome powers. I bet they would give you some too!”

“I don’t know if I want powers,” the boy said.

“Don’t you want to be better? Your family came to America so wouldn’t they want you to be American? What is more American than being a superhero?”

“Hotdogs?” the boy suggested.

The audience laughs.

“You’re funny, they’ll like that. All you have to say is yes.”

The boy opened his mouth but froze before saying anything. Mindmeld moved his hand back.

“Hey, Andrew? The scene’s over. Get a move on.”

“No. It isn’t. He still has to respond,” Mindmeld said.

“We can’t give it all away to the audience yet. That would be bad writing on my part,” the Director said. Mindmeld could hear his steps growing closer.

“I need to know what he said,” Mindmeld said.

“Oh, my sweet, sweet boy. You already do know.”

“No! No, I don’t. I—I need to know!”

“Alright, if that’s how you want to play things.”

The Director yanked Mindmeld backward and he slid across the ground. The Director stood above him and grasped Mindmeld’s throat as he lifted him into the air.

“I could always just fire you and replace you with another actor,” the Director said.

Mindmeld reached his ungloved hand out and squeezed it around the Director’s throat. The Director dropped him and staggered backward.

“WOAH! Going for my memories. Can you feel the rush of it all? Has my mind joined the union? Is it all overwhelming to you?”

Mindmeld braced himself for the surge, but his mind remained unchanged. He looked toward the young boy, still frozen before speaking. Mindmeld dashed over to the tree where they had

sat together, but something wrapped around his wrist, tugging him backward to the ground. The Director held a belt in his hand, pulling against the other end coiled around Mindmeld. Once Mindmeld was close enough, the Director put his palm against Mindmeld's chest and belts sprung outward and into the ground, pinning Mindmeld down.

The Director stood up as Mindmeld struggled against his restraints and began to speak, "Sorry for the confusion folks. We'll be right back after we resolve this."

*BLACKOUT*

*The curtains close. When they reopen, the stage is divided into two sections. The left section is dark. On the right section, Teen Demon speaks with Beekeeper in her cell. Teen Demon sits in a chair backward, leaning it forward against the table Beekeeper sits on the other side of.*

*Beekeeper was in prison clothes instead of her usual thick mesh anti-sting suit, but she still wore the top portion of her suit and her face was covered with a straw plate.*

TEEN DEMON

So, then she asked me if I was just trying to prove something about myself.

BEEKEEPER

That'zzz a real low blow. I can't believe she would say something so mean.

TEEN DEMON

I know! Although, it is all good now because my mom gave a really inspiring speech.

BEEKEEPER

She izzz really an inzzzpiring woman. You are lucky to have her in your life.

TEEN DEMON

Yeah. What do you think my next play is?

BEEKEEPER

Well, she izzz quite hotheaded. I wouldn't take it to heart. I get where she is coming from, it'zzz not so fun being here. I think you could reach out one more time, emphasizzzzing that you are juzzzt there to be a friend. If she doezzzn't bite thizzz time, then you did what you could.

TEEN DEMON

Okay, I'll give it one more shot. Thanks for the advice, Rosa.

BEEKEEPER

It'zzz my pleasure.

TEEN DEMON

I got one more thing to ask.

*Teen Demon leans in closer to Beekeeper  
and begins to whisper.*

Have you noticed anything unusual here?

BEEKEEPER

Like what?

TEEN DEMON

Just anything off.

BEEKEEPER

Now that you do mention it. I do sometimezzz  
hear tortured screaming in the later hourzzz  
of the evening.

TEEN DEMON

And they come from below?

BEEKEEPER

Yezzz. Alwayszzz from below.

TEEN DEMON

That is very helpful to know. Thanks for your  
help, Beekeeper.

BEEKEEPER

Thankzzz for visiting. You are always so fun to talk to. Your brain izzz so unique.

One requezzzt. Could you check on the apiary again this week?

TEEN DEMON

You know I'm good for it.

*The right section dims and the left section lights up to reveal Pillbug-Man and Momentum sitting on a bench in the park.*

MOMENTUM

You ever think about moving?

PILLBUG-MAN

Not really, you?

MOMENTUM

No, not really.

PILLBUG-MAN

I just don't see the point. Anywhere looks pretty during a sunset. Besides, I need to stay close to here so I can make sure to solidify my memorial bench.

MOMENTUM

Hmm, you make a good point.



PILLBUG-MAN

You think I've earned a bench?

MOMENTUM

Of course, you have. I don't think you'll ever know how much you truly contributed. Even with me, I mean this support group is nice and all, but it wouldn't mean anything without you.

PILLBUG-MAN

You're too kind.

MOMENTUM

No, I'm serious, Man. I spent my whole childhood being told what it meant to be a man. I had to be tough or cruel or brooding to be real in someone's eyes and I knew it was always crap, but after the breakup I thought, even if just a little, that maybe that kind of thinking really was true.

PILLBUG-MAN

*Pillbug-Man wipes at his face.*

Oh, jeez. You're making me cry a little.

MOMENTUM

I saw how Justice and some of the others were on TV when I was a kid. I saw when they acted like that too. I won't turn out like them.

*Pillbug-Man hugs Momentum.*

PILLBUG-MAN

Thank you. Thank you. . .

*Pillbug-Man's sentence trails off as he sniffles.*

*A passerby stops, stares at Momentum and Pillbug-Man hugging on a bench in the middle of the park, then continues walking.*

*The left section dims and the right section lights up to reveal Teen Demon sitting across from Wendigo Woman. They are playing checkers.*

WENDIGO WOMAN

I didn't expect you to come back.

*Wendigo Woman moves a piece, then Teen Demon does.*

TEEN DEMON

I was not going to until I spoke with Tinkerer and Beekeeper.

*Teen Demon and Wendigo Woman continue moving pieces as they talk.*

You were right . . . about some of it.

*Teen Demon moves a piece.*

I was just supposed to talk to you, but I thought it would be easy to fix a human's mind. I can see that it is not.

*Wendigo Woman picks up a piece and moves it.*

WENDIGO WOMAN

Now I think I am seeing the whole picture here . . . Yeah, you were pissing me off. Some teenager coming in here telling me how I'm supposed to feel.

TEEN DEMON

I'm not a teenager.

WENDIGO WOMAN

Okay. I'm not in jail then.

TEEN DEMON

Very funny. I will just come to talk, that is it.

WENDIGO WOMAN

Okay, and I'll tell you what, I'll think about another name. Probably not Mrs. Pissy though.

TEEN DEMON

I can work with that. To prove how serious I am about this, I will investigate this

prison. I think there might be some legitimacy to your claims, and I will get to the bottom of it. I just need the right moment to investigate.

No one should have to sleep at night hearing screams.

#### WENDIGO WOMAN

Thank you.

*They continue playing checkers as the stage dims.*

*A spotlight shines down on the center of the stage revealing Mindmeld writhing on the ground, trying to shake free from his bindings.*

The Director loomed over Mindmeld. “Is this all from Stupendous Man’s PRODIGAL son?”

“Don’t say his name!” Mindmeld shouted.

“Why can’t I? I know him as well as you do,” the Director said. He crossed his arms behind his back and walked around Mindmeld.

“Come on. I made you stronger. BREAK FREE!”

The Director paused after shouting to see if Mindmeld broke free. Upon seeing Mindmeld still stuck to the ground, he kicked Mindmeld. His pointed dress shoes dug into Mindmeld’s stomach.

“You were the pinnacle of our creation, yet you are insistent on using just a fraction of your power. To suffer through so much

and be satisfied as a background character in the great play of life is appalling. Why must you hide behind her like some side character? You are the MAIN CHARACTER! ACT LIKE IT!”

“I don’t want to be that!”

“I DON’T CARE! Dozens of heroes in action right now and just one of the Alpha Squadron members would be strong enough to take down every one of them at once, but not you. You are the only one out of this mess of has-beens and never-will-bes that could actually rival the strength of the old days.”

“This isn’t real. This isn’t real. I just need to wake up.”

The Director grabbed Mindmeld’s head and held it steady, so they were looking at each other. Mindmeld stared at his bloody mask and the Director’s eyes couldn’t be seen behind the reflection on his glasses.

“Look at me! Do I not look real to you?” the Director asked.

“Stop! I don’t want to look.”

“The script doesn’t say you can look away yet,” the Director said as he kept Mindmeld’s shaking head steady.

A spotlight turned on and the young boy sitting next to the tree could be seen in the corner of Mindmeld’s eyes.

“I know you loved plays, boy, but stop hiding in one! You are MY creation. I saved YOU. Do not hide from it,” the Director said.

Mindmeld watched the boy talk to Lavender Lad in the shade of the tree as he pushed his arms against the restraints.

“I won’t let you ruin him. You don’t get to tell him what he’s supposed to be!” Mindmeld said.

“It’s too late. I already—” the Director was cut short as a blue blur crashed into him. Mindmeld looked up to see a golden cape fluttering in wind that could not be felt. A man of unparalleled strength in a blue jumpsuit with an S on his chest stood in front of him, Stupendous Man. Stupendous Man reached down and pinched the restraints, snapping them open.

“Hello, Andrew.”

Mindmeld sprung forward and hugged him. Stupendous Man rubbed his knuckle against Mindmeld’s head, rustling his hair.

“I missed you,” Stupendous Man said.

“I miss you too.”

“What the hell is he doing here?” the Director asked.

“It’s his head, isn’t it?” Stupendous Man said.

The Director grunted, then began to run toward them. Stupendous Man knelt so he was eye-level with Mindmeld.

“I’m going to hold him off. You get out of here. Find Tinkerer.”

“Come with me, please.”

“You know I can’t. Don’t worry, you have all you need out there. I love you,” Stupendous Man.

“Love you too, Dad,” Mindmeld said.

Stupendous Man turned around and flew toward the Director. He uppercut the Director sending a burst of air outward

pushing Mindmeld toward the spotlight. The Director was flung upward, and Stupendous Man grabbed him midair then threw him into the ground. The Director skid across the ground and Stupendous Man appeared in front of him, then kicked him to the side, sending him toppling in another direction.

Mindmeld got up and ran toward the spotlight, closing the distance between himself and the young boy. The ground shook with each attack from Stupendous Man. Once he had closed enough distance, Mindmeld leapt forward with his arm outstretched. The tip of his finger made contact with the boy's forehead.

*The stage is dark. When the lights turn back on, Markie and Microcosm are in Markie's room on the left side of the stage. The right side of the stage is dark.*

*Microcosm is playing with the theremin as Markie floats around the room.*

MICROCOSM

This instrument makes no sense. Admit, you're just learning how to do this because of how complicated it is.

MARKIE

You are correct.

MICROCOSM

*Shocked.*

You're not supposed to actually admit that when someone asks.

MARKIE

Then I am not.

MICROCOSM

Very funny.

MARKIE

It would only make sense that I play a complex instrument. I am the third edition and the only one left. I am meant to be the best out of them all.

MICROCOSM

Who were the first two?

MARKIE

First, there was Mark-1. He tried to kill us. Then, my fake father was Mark-2. Although, perhaps him being Mark-2 makes him my actual father.

MICROCOSM

I—Wow, that's a lot.

MARKIE

I doubt either of them could have played the theremin.

MICROCOSM



You're probably right about that one. I'm kind of the Mark-2 for my family.

MARKIE

Do you think you are better than the original?

MICROCOSM

Not yet.

MARKIE

Do humans always improve with each new version?

MICROCOSM

Not always.

MARKIE

Then why bother with new versions?

MICROCOSM

It's the same reason Tinkerer didn't stop at Mark-2. We want family.

MARKIE

And what do humans do when the new version is worse?

MICROCOSM

It doesn't change anything. They're just as valuable.

MARKIE

That's—that's good to hear.

MICROCOSM

Markie, is everything alright with you?

MARKIE

All of my systems are functioning properly—

*Markie is interrupted by a knocking.*

TINKERER

*From offstage.*

Markie, dinner is ready!

MARKIE

I'll be down!

*Speaking at a low volume.*

I'll see you later.

*Microcosm gives a thumbs up and falls through a trapdoor in the stage.*

*The left side of the stage dims and the right-side lights up to reveal Mindmeld laying motionless on his bed. There is a knocking, but he does not move.*

TINKERER

*From offstage.*

Andrew, dinner!

*Mindmeld does not move. Tinkerer knocks again.*

Andrew! You okay?

*Mindmeld does not move. A loud kick can be heard and then the sound of a door swinging open. Tinkerer runs onto the stage.*

*She finds Mindmeld still on his bed. His eyes are open and a pool of drool has formed on his pillow.*

TINKERER

Oh my god! Andrew!

*Tinkerer reaches into her pockets and puts on her gloves. She leans down and listens to his chest. She can hear his heart beating steady. She shakes him, but he does not stir.*

No no no. Come on, Andrew. Wake up!

*Mindmeld does not move.*

Okay. Okay. Just take a second to think. He's still breathing. I just gotta snap him back to reality.

*The hair on Tinkerer's arm begins to stand and it tastes as if she was*

*holding a screwdriver in her mouth. The TV in Mindmeld's room begins to vibrate.*

*Tinkerer runs to the window.*

What the hell? There's nothing out there.

*Tinkerer's skin is now tingling.*

House! Activate electric shielding around this room. Now!

*The walls flip over to reveal a rubber-padded backside.*

We're going to figure this out. We will.

*The right side of the stage is quiet for a second then it flashes pink and a ringing sound plays from the speakers.*

*When the pink light dims, it is apparent that Mindmeld's room is a mess with various items burnt. Tinkerer is on the ground against the wall opposite Mindmeld who is now laying on the ground where his bed once was.*

*Teen Demon, Tara, and Markie can be heard shouting out for them in the background, but it's muffled. As the stage dims, they run into the room to see if Tinkerer is okay.*

BLACKOUT

END SCENE

### Scene 3

*The stage is dark. A white spotlight turns on and Mindmeld is standing in it.*

MINDMELD

Why are you still watching me? Do you want to see me break? You could have left. No one is keeping you here. Does this bring you joy? Are you relishing this chance to watch me crack?

You do not need to worry about Tinkerer. She is fine. She survived. I—I do not know what is happening to me.

*Mindmeld paces around the stage as the spotlight follows him.*

I would like to think you are still here because you are waiting to see me succeed . . . because—because you believe I can. Yeah, I want to go with that.

*The spotlight dims and when the stage lights turn on Teen Demon is sitting across from Wendigo Woman.*

TEEN DEMON

What about a name like Poltergeist? Or maybe Spirit Slinger?

WENDIGO WOMAN

You are quite a creative kid, but what if we just stop the whole fake name thing. Let's just use Claire.

TEEN DEMON

But you can't use your real name. If you do that, villains will find the people you care about and kill them.

CLAIRE

Who is there left to kill?

TEEN DEMON

I-Erm.

CLAIRE

*Laughing.*

Haha! I am just messing with you. I still got a mom out there. I just think you overestimate my profile. We can start worrying about that sort of thing if I get a nemesis.

TEEN DEMON

Alright, Claire. I'll be back to hang out again.

*Teen Demon leans in so he can whisper.*

And next time I hope to have information for you. I will make sure to visit a little later

today to try and catch what you have been hearing.

CLAIRE

Sounds great, Teen Demon.

*Teen Demon picks up his suitcase and walks off to the right. The stage dims.*

*A spotlight shines down on Teen Demon as he walks in place on the stage with his suitcase in his hands. Two men in white coats push past him unaware of his presence as they flip through papers on their clipboards. Teen Demon drops his suitcase and picks it back up as the men continue to walk forward. Teen Demon looks up to see the men's coats then puts his suitcase back down.*

*He follows them on all fours careful to stick to the shadows not putting too much weight on any step. As the men reached the right side of the stage, another spotlight turned on to reveal an enormous steel elevator car.*

*The taller man with his hair spiked up presses some buttons on a keypad next to the elevator and then lowers his eyes to a scanner. As he does this, Teen Demon crawls up the wall, so he is now above the elevator door.*

*The doors open and the men step into the elevator. Teen Demon crawls into the*

*elevator crossing over the top portion of the door too small to be noticed by the men looking at paperwork. He clings to the ceiling.*

*The spotlights dims and a flat, red light as wide as the car trails from the bottom of the elevator car to the top of it then jumps to the bottom to move up again, mimicking the light of passing floors.*

SCIENTIST

How is she today?

DR. ITICUS

Brash. Complete your diagnostics then we are done until tomorrow.

*A bell chimes. The red light disappears, and the stage lights up to reveal a room filled with computers and test tubes. Something rests chained up on the left side of the room.*

*The scientists step out of the elevator and Teen Demon sneaks out behind them sticking to the edges of the stage ducking behind computers while he follows the scientists. As Teen Demon gets closer to the chained-up creature, he can see that this being has blue skin unlike anything he had seen before. Her hands were locked in gauntlets chained to the ground. Metal bars were bent*



*around her body keeping her from moving.  
A metal ring covered one of her eyes and  
her other eye was missing from its  
socket.*

*Dr. Iticus stares at the beast as the  
other scientist darts around the room  
collecting data from various  
instruments.*

DR. ITICUS

Care to speak today?

*The chained-up monster does not respond.*

Fine. We don't need you to talk to do what we  
need.

*The second scientist returns to Dr.  
Iticus' side.*

SCIENTIST

I got what I need. Let's get out of here  
before another incident happens.

DR. ITICUS

*Dr. Iticus speaks as he walks toward the  
elevator door.*

See you tomorrow.

*The two scientists enter the elevator,  
and the door closes behind them leaving  
Teen Demon and the woman alone in the*

*room. The lights in the room shut off and only a spotlight remains on the woman. Teen Demon slowly walks closer to her.*

THE WOMAN

You don't smell human. What are you?

*Teen Demon stops in his tracks. The woman tilts her head, so she is facing him, the chains rattle as she moves. Teen Demon stares into her empty eye socket.*

Do not be afraid to speak.

TEEN DEMON

Teen Demon.

THE WOMAN

Hmm. A funny name. Are you truly a demon?

TEEN DEMON

Yeah, in the flesh.

THE WOMAN

*She laughs to herself before speaking again.*

This planet never ceases to amaze me.

TEEN DEMON

What's your name?

THE WOMAN

Atomsplitter.

*Teen Demon freezes, then slowly steps backward. His tail is tucked between his legs which shake just slightly.*

ATOMSPLITTER

It's okay, you have nothing to fear, child. I know you must have heard about what I did in Tokyo, but know I only care about Justice. I will kill him once I escape from here, but that is all. I will not hurt you.

How is he doing these days? I imagine you see him on the television.

TEEN DEMON

He is . . . he is doing well. The . . . um .  
. . Alpha Squadron is very strong.

ATOMSPLITTER

Good. I didn't want them to soften in my absence.

TEEN DEMON

How long . . . how long have you been here?

ATOMSPLITTER

Decades. These humans move slow. It took them years to find a way to even draw blood from me. I'm sure you can understand as an external entity how pathetic their minds are.

TEEN DEMON

I . . . I don't think I can break you out of here.

*Teen Demon lifts up his mask to wipe away the sweat on his face.*

ATOMSPLITTER

That is fine. I did not expect you too. I'll get out of here on my own when the day is right. When I feel ready, I will break free from these chains and take my vengeance.

TEEN DEMON

I could . . . I think I could stay and talk for a little if you would like.

ATOMSPLITTER

I would not mind if you feel willing.

*The stage dims. When the stage lights back up, Burnout, Tara, and Momentum are sitting in a red booth inside Tom's Diner.*

*Momentum sips from a chocolate milkshake as Burnout folds up a straw. Tara is looking at a menu. "Kingston" by Faye Webster plays over the speakers. The sun has just set. Tara's sunglasses are sitting on the table and Momentum wears his on the top of his head.*

BURNOUT

Check this out. I'm going to make the worm grow.

*Tara sets down her menu. Burnout puts their straw in their water then drips some water on the wrapper. It expands outward.*

MOMENTUM

No way. That is sick. Let me try that.

*Tara giggles as Momentum grabs his ripped-up wrapper and tries to fold it up.*

BURNOUT

It's nice to get a chance to talk outside of group. I sometimes feel like I don't get a chance to really know you all . . . like the fun side that you use most days.

MOMENTUM

*Momentum speaks without looking up from his wrapper.*

Be wary. I have a lot of layers. I'm pretty complex.

TARA

Well, you don't have to worry, Emerson, because I'm known for being easy to read.

*Momentum drops some water on his folded wrapper. It expands outward, although to a less impressive extent. Burnout gives him a fake clap.*

BURNOUT

Your worm looks a little dead.

MOMENTUM

He's resting.

BURNOUT

If you insist. I'm going to use the restroom real quick, feel free to order without me.

*Burnout steps off stage.*

MOMENTUM

This is nice.

TARA

What? Your worm?

MOMENTUM

No, us all hanging out.

TARA

It is.

MOMENTUM

Kinda funny that they're playing Faye here.  
Wouldn't be what you'd expect.

TARA

Yeah, I suppose so. At the least, I feel "She  
Won't Go Away" would be a better pick for a  
diner.

MOMENTUM

Probably.

*Momentum reaches for Tara's straw  
sitting on the table, still in its  
wrapper.*

You mind?

*Tara shakes her head no. Momentum  
carefully pops out the straw and begins  
to fold the wrapper.*

It's kinda funny. I got dumped, you did the  
dumping.

TARA

I don't know if I've ever found any of it really funny.

MOMENTUM

Well, not really "funny". More, just isn't it kinda weird to be two sides of the same coin. I gotta say, I would have rather been you.

TARA

Why's that?

MOMENTUM

It must have been nice to be the one to decide when it was time to end the movie.

TARA

It's not that easy. Assuming you aren't breaking up in the heat of the moment, it takes a lot of thought. You have to find the right time for it. It can't be around holidays, family events, or any of that sort of thing.

MOMENTUM

Yeah?

TARA

Yeah. Let's take the twelve months of the year and apply it to our circumstances with a high school to college thing.



Cut out November, December, and January for the holidays. Cut out February because, well that's obvious. Already, that's a third of them gone. Cut out May, June, July, and August as that's summer. April is pretty much summer.

That leaves September, October, and March. Cut out March because if you made it that far then why are you doing this math. That leaves September and October. I call those two months The Culling.

MOMENTUM

Shit. She broke up with me in September.

TARA

That's what I'm saying! Check on social media that time of the year. It's a brutal time. Whether conscious or not, people pick those two months.

Point being, it's not easy picking a time for such a thing. It would have been nice not to have to think about it until I absolutely had to.

MOMENTUM

Dang, you're kinda cold, but in a cool way. I just think I've been going about it all wrong.

*"One Step Ahead" by Aretha Franklin  
starts playing.*

You always hear that opposites attract thing.  
I don't believe that, not anymore. That sort  
of thing only works in movies.

TARA

And books.

MOMENTUM

Eh. Maybe.

*Momentum looks over at Tara's  
sunglasses.*

You know how to tell if a pair of glasses are  
polarized?

TARA

No, it hasn't come up yet for me.

MOMENTUM

Well, my dad taught me once.

*Momentum grabs his sunglasses off his  
head and Tara's off the table then holds  
them in the air behind one another.*

If you hold two pairs of glasses in front of  
each other then tilt one of them about ninety  
degrees, the lens will darken if the pairs  
are polarized.

*Momentum tilts his pair to the right and  
the lens darkens.*

Good to see you didn't cheap out on these.  
You can take yours back.

*Tara leans forward and takes her pair of  
glasses out of Momentum's hands.  
Momentum sets his pair back on his head.*

I think that's more how we should go about  
things.

TARA

So, pairs of glasses should date pairs of  
glasses?

MOMENTUM

More or less. I think if you find someone a  
lot like you who sees the world just a little  
differently, that's when you can tell if  
something is real.

I don't know. I just think it's a fun  
analogy. I think I get it from Pillbug-Man.  
He's always talking about arches. At the very  
least you can use it when you go shopping for  
sunglasses next.

TARA

I'll . . . be sure to keep that in mind.

*Burnout walks back in with their phone  
in their hand and sits back down.*

BURNOUT

Guys, I saw something on my phone. While I was gone, I saw some headlines about a monster attacking Skum City.

MOMENTUM

How bad is it?

BURNOUT

Looks pretty bad.

TARA

I'm sure someone else can handle it. Abraham wanted us to let stuff breathe.

BURNOUT

I know, but he doesn't know what it's really like. Yeah, it'd be great if I didn't have to worry about this. There should be some other heroes out there dealing with this, but where are they? We live in a world where the previous hero teams dropped the ball, and we have the power to pick it up.

I think Abraham's ideals are smart, but I also feel he maybe is used to living in a world where the Alpha Squadron dealt with everything. I . . . I haven't forgotten what Abraham said. I've narrowed my scope; I don't worry about what happens outside of the Points and what happens when I sleep, but this is just across the river and happening right now. I wouldn't have brought it up if it wasn't something that could be quickly

dealt with and with the three of us working together it would be no sweat.

We could deal with this, save some lives, and be back here for milkshakes.

MOMENTUM

I smell a team-up brewing!

*Momentum turns to look off stage, presumably at a waiter.*

We'll be right back! Just going to stop a supervillain real quick.

TARA

Okay, I'm going to help. I'm not doing it because I think this should be your concern, but I'm not going to let you do this alone.

*The stage dims as they run off. When it lights back up, the stage is decorated to look like Tinkerer's dining room. Tinkerer and Mindmeld are sitting at the table. A metal chandelier hangs above them, illuminating the area.*

TINKERER

Well, Tara is out with her friends, Teen Demon had a long day at the containment facility, and your sister doesn't seem to want to come down for dinner.

MINDMELD

That's okay. I don't mind talking with you!

TINKERER

You're too kind. I . . . Maybe we could take this opportunity to talk about what happened the other day.

MINDMELD

I'm sorry.

TINKERER

Oh, Honey, that's not your fault. It barely even hurt. I—I just worry it could be something more. I haven't been completely honest with you. There have been some moments where you've lapsed before.

You don't talk, you barely emote, it doesn't even seem like you.

MINDMELD

How many times has this happened?

TINKERER

Just a few with Blademaster. I—I'm so sorry I didn't tell you sooner. I just—I didn't see the reason to worry you if you hadn't hurt anyone and we didn't know how to address it yet.

MINDMELD

*Mindmeld looks toward the audience.*

I always knew she knew, but she doesn't know that. I really don't care that she kept this from me, but it would be a waste of time to explain all this to her, so I'll just play dumb here.

*Mindmeld looks back toward Tinkerer.*

Oh? I—I understand, Mom.

TINKERER

That's so good to hear.

*Tinkerer looks down and wipes her face.*

MINDMELD

What's wrong with me, Mom?

TINKERER

Nothing. You're perfect. We just must get the hang of these powers. I have some theories. We worked through Tara's anklet; I see no reason why we can't solve this either.

*Markie floats in from offstage.*

MARKIE

My apologies for the delay. I was just wrapping up something in my room.

TINKERER

It's no problem! Take a seat!

*Markie depowers her thrusters over a chair.*

*Tinkerer and Mindmeld eat as a solar panel pops out of Markie's head.*

*Teen Demon runs in from offstage and crashes against the screen door swinging it open. It slowly closes, creaking, while Teen Demon hunches over to catch his breath.*

TINKERER

Is everything okay? You had called to let me know you were going to be there a little extra, but you look like you've seen a ghost.

TEEN DEMON

I-I . . . It was—She is . . .

TINKERER

Take a breath, Honey. It's no rush. Let me get you some water.

*Tinkerer gets up and goes to the cabinet.*

TEEN DEMON

It's Atomsplitter . . . she's alive . . . and she thinks Justice is still alive too.



*The glass in Tinkerer's hands drops to the ground and shatters.*

*A lavender tinted spotlight shines down on Mindmeld.*

MARKIE

I can help clean that up.

*Markie begins hovering over to the shattered glass.*

TINKERER

She's . . . she's still alive?

TEEN DEMON

I saw her. They've been keeping her detained.

*Mindmeld sits still in his chair as Markie cleans up the glass.*

TINKERER

Did she look hurt?

TEEN DEMON

They had her chained up. I couldn't really tell. What should we do?

*Microcosm pops up from under the stage. She takes off her mask. Her eyes are watery.*

MICROCOSM

You said she's still alive?

TEEN DEMON

What in the hell is she doing here?!?!

MARKIE

Morgan, what are you doing?

MICROCOSM

I'm sorry. I was on my way out when I heard.  
I—I need to know.

TEEN DEMON

What do you mean on the way out?

MINDMELD

*Muttering to himself.*

No. This doesn't make sense. Atomsplitter  
should be dead. Microcosm is a villain.  
They're not fitting their roles.

*The spotlight on him begins flashing  
different colors. The spotlight turns  
maroon, then orange, then violet, then  
aquamarine, then red, then blue, then  
lime, then yellow, then dark green. The  
colors continue to rapidly cycle as the  
others discuss.*

MARKIE

Do not worry. She is a friend, my friend.

TEEN DEMON

A friend? You remember the time she blew my head right open?

MICROCOSM

I am sincerely sorry about that.

TEEN DEMON

No! You do not get to just apologize for that.

MICROCOSM

I thought your whole thing was working with villains.

TEEN DEMON

Aw Heaven. How much has Markie told you?

MICROCOSM

Enough to know that what I did was wrong. I just visited Markie because she is a friend.

TEEN DEMON

Well go look somewhere else!

MARKIE

Please, Teen Demon. There are things only we can understand about each other.

TEEN DEMON

Markie . . . I . . .

MINDMELD

*Muttering.*

So, Atomsplitter is now living. Microcosm is a good guy, or is she? That's okay. We just have to modify some things. We can keep track of it all.

TEEN DEMON

Mom, what do we do?

MICROCOSM

Please, I'm not a threat. I just need to know about Atomsplitter.

*Mindmeld collapses to the ground.*

TINKERER

Andy!

*Tinkerer runs over to Mindmeld.*

MINDMELD

Get away from me! I think it's happening again. Everyone, get back!

TEEN DEMON

What is he talking about? Is there going to be another electric blast?

MICROCOSM

Electric blast?

*Mindmeld stumbles to his feet.*

MINDMELD

They . . . they know.

TINKERER

Who, Honey? Who knows?

MINDMELD

THEM!

*Mindmeld swings his arms out toward the audience. The spotlight continues flashing on him.*

They know something is wrong with me. They've known this whole time!

TINKERER

Honey, who are you talking about? There is no one there.

*Mindmeld collapses again. He pushes his hands against the floor and manages to*

*lift his head off the ground. A pink aura begins to radiate off him. The overwhelming pressure of one trillion neurons worth of thoughts within his hundred billion pushes against the inside of his skull.*

*Tinkerer puts on her gloves and sits down next to Mindmeld. She tilts his head, so they are looking at each other.*

MINDMELD

They know something is wrong with me. I—I know they do. I know they do. I'm sorry, Mom. I tried to hide it. I really did. I wanted to be strong like he was.

*Mindmeld begins sobbing.*

TINKERER

I don't understand, Honey. Come on, Andrew. You can do it. Remember who you are!

MINDMELD

I—I can't!

*Mindmeld screams. When Mindmeld screams out in pain, it is not just one voice, but almost a dozen. Hundreds of years of memories squeezed within a body built for less than twenty. The spotlight continues to flash over him.*

TINKERER

You're our son. You're a superhero. This is your home. You're safe here.

*Tinkerer picks Mindmeld up and they walk toward the screen door.*

Let's just get you outside. We can sort this out there.

*Tinkerer walks Mindmeld through the door and off the stage. The others follow them.*

Tinkerer's hand remained pressed against Mindmeld's back guiding him away from the house. Sweat beaded on his forehead as Mindmeld gasped for air. The cool midnight air burnt his lungs as he inhaled. The charade was up. Everyone knew now.

"You all should get back. There might be another blast," Tinkerer said as she laid Mindmeld down on the grass.

"I'm going to be here for him this time. There's part of me in there. I won't let him deal with it alone," Teen Demon said.

"The odds of helping my brother increase the more of us are here," Markie said as she floated forward.

"If it is an explosion you are concerned about then I could shrink him for a little," Microcosm said.

"Just stay back!" Teen Demon said.

"I appreciate your offer, but I don't want to lose track of him," Tinkerer said.

At this point the pink aura pulsating from Mindmeld's body coated the trees highlighting their rustling leaves. The stars above could be seen; the Big Dipper watching over them. A light breeze blew past them all originating from Mindmeld's body.

"Mom . . ." Mindmeld said, his body shivering with an unknown energy fermenting right beneath the skin.

"What is it?"

"It hurts."

"Don't hold it in. It's okay to let it all go. We're outside now," Tinkerer said.

"I don't know how to let it go," Mindmeld said.

"How did it end up like this?" Microcosm asked.

"I don't know. His powers have always been a little difficult, but it's never been like this," Teen Demon said.

"Can you remember our words?" Tinkerer asked.

"It's not that. I remember everything!" Mindmeld shouted.

The power surging off Mindmeld increased, pushing Tinkerer backward. Teen Demon pulled the sword off his back and swung it into the ground. Microcosm and Markie flew backward. Microcosm flew into a tree, knocking her head against it. She fell unconscious as she flew farther into the woods. Teen Demon alternated between his sword and his claws to inch his way toward his brother.

"Andy, are you in there?" Teen Demon shouted over the waves of energy. A faint humming grew louder and louder.



“TD, get away!”

“No, you did not flee when I was in danger, so neither will—

”

Teen Demon is cut off by Mindmeld’s shriek. A pink flash blinded everyone followed by one last surge of energy pushing them all away from Mindmeld. After this, the field grew quiet. Tinkerer, Markie, and Teen Demon picked themselves back up. Markie hovered over to Microcosm.

“Is it over?” Teen Demon asked.

“Microcosm is unconscious.”

“Oh, so that was not too bad,” Teen Demon said.

Tinkerer looked over to Teen Demon and said, “Mindmeld is unconscious too.”

“I WoOulN’T be so sure.”

When they turned to look at Mindmeld, he was now standing, his eyes glowing pink.

“Andy, you are unharmed!” Teen Demon shouted.

“Don’t be so confldEnt. anDrew Isn’t hEre, only MindmEld.”

Mindmeld reached his arm forward and pink electricity sprung out from his hands grabbing Tinkerer and lifting her into the air.

“Cease this. You are hurting mother.”

“Andy, you’re scaring me,” Teen Demon said.

Mindmeld swung his hand and Tinkerer went flying into a tree. She fell to the ground and did not move.

“That’s enough, Andy!” Teen Demon shouted as he ran forward. Mindmeld lifted his hand up. An enormous drumstick made of electricity formed in the air. Mindmeld swung his hand downward. The drumstick crashed into Teen Demon and crackled against his skin, burning his flesh. Teen Demon screamed out in pain.

A tranquilizer dart flew out from Markie’s hands only to be met by a chalkboard made of electricity that formed in front of Mindmeld, stopping the dart.

“stoP resisting. LEt me be who i wAS mEant to.”

Mindmeld clapped his hands.

## Chapter 7

Tara flew down from the sky then set Momentum and Burnout onto the ground. They stood in a street toward the outskirts of Skum City. Civilians ran past them, bumping into them as they fled. People could be heard screaming from within the building. The streetlights had been destroyed with the top half of the poles flung into the buildings. Down the street, a mass of darkness spiraled across the street crashing into the buildings and flinging more streetlights into them. Tendrils spiraled out from the creature writhing their way into buildings snuffing out any lights they could find. The street was just barely illuminated by the night sky.

A green glow emanated from Tara's suit, red electricity crackled from Burnout's feet, and a blue light shined from the bracelet Momentum pulled out his pocket. He rubbed the bracelet. Tara looked at him, confused.

"Don't judge. My people have their methods," Momentum said.

He raised the bracelet up to his mouth and spoke.

"Yeah, I'm here now. I think it's Serbenet. He's bigger than I've ever seen him. We could use the cavalry."

"Serbenet?" Tara asked.

"Yeah, we've run into him a few times before. He's just some guy who got a hold of an artifact that allows him to manifest darkness. You know how in a sandstorm there is sand in the air?"

“Yep, I knew that,” Burnout said.

“Well, imagine that when it’s dark it isn’t the absence of light, but the presence of ‘dark particles’ this guy can bend to his will,” Momentum said as he pulled his leg behind his back, stretching it out.

“That doesn’t make any sense,” Tara said.

“Makes enough sense to me. I’m ready,” Burnout said.

“So, the more darkness the stronger he is?” Tara asked.

“Yeah, more or less,” Momentum said.

“Alright, then I’ll just take that away from him. You two handle the civilians, I’ll keep him busy,” Tara said. The back of her suit molded into a jetpack, and she blasted off.

“Momentum, can you get the people toward the top of the buildings? I can handle the bottom floors, but the top floors are going to take too much out of me,” Burnout said.

“On it,” Momentum said.

Burnout slid down their goggles and, in an instant, they were gone. They raced through the streets sliding through the waves of civilians and into the bottom floors of the buildings. Burnout moved with such speed that the soles of their boots left burn marks on the wooden floors as they raced through the buildings. They moved through each floor methodically grabbing the children first, then the adults.

Momentum whirled through the air using the broken streetlights as anchors to spiral toward each person leaning outside their window.

“Stay still and grab something to slide down with!”

Momentum shouted out.

When he reached a window someone was leaning out of, he would use one cord to anchor himself to the side of the building and shoot the other cord to the ground creating a zipline. As soon as the last person in the group made it down, he bounced to the next window.

Once Tara was close enough, her arms molded into blasters, and she began raining bursts of energy into the mass of darkness. Tendrils jutted out looking to pierce her, but the suit reacted before even she could, molding her chest plate into a jetpack to briefly boost her backward.

“Turn up the brightness. I’m going in!” Tara shouted. The green aura from the cracks in her suit grew brighter until she mimicked that of a lightning bug. Tara dove into Serbenet dodging his tendrils. She blasted onto the ground right in the center of the mass. Serbenet molded around her light creating a small vacuum in the shape of a sphere where she stood. Tendrils jutted out attempting to spear her.

Tara’s arms molded into blades, and she cut off the darkness each time it reached out. When that wasn’t enough, two arms formed at the back of her suit swinging automatically at the attacks.

Still, she was surrounded by an onslaught. Tara's boosters activated and once she was in the air her legs molded into blades. Hundreds of tendrils spit outward each minute. Tara spun through the air cutting each of them with all six blades. One of them snuck past her defenses and wrapped around Tara's waist.

The tendril receded into the ground slamming Tara against it. She bounced upward and a flurry of tendrils slammed against her before pulling her down against the ground again. Tara activated her boosters, but the tendrils held her down. The darkness in front of her moved backward then formed a large maw. The mouth opened and a tongue fell outward from which a man walked out on.

Serbenet's actual body was covered in a black cloak. He lowered it to reveal a face coated in blackened veins. When he spoke, the spit sticking to his teeth was a murky tar color.

"It was quite moronic of you to dive into the darkness. No hero has ever tried such a thing," he said.

Tara's boosters fired off once more, but she still could not fly off the ground.

"Keep him talking while I rewire your blasters," Tara's suit said.

"Why do you squirm? Is this not comfortable? Stop flying for one second and listen."

There was silence. Tara looked around. The darkness at the edge of her aura crashed against the boundary like waves on the shore seamlessly receding back into the larger mass.

“I don’t know, you look a little pasty to me,” Tara said.

“Do not mock the darkness! It is the only thing that understands me,” he said.

“Hmm. You feel very Tumblr-coded.”

“What’s a ‘Tumbler’?” he asked.

“It’s a drinking glass with straight sides and no handle or stem,” she said.

“You make no sense,” he said.

“I am ready,” her suit said.

“Well, this has been nice. Listen, I like being a night owl as much as the next person, but the bumner is that morning always has to come eventually,” Tara said. She ripped her arm out from the tendrils. Her free arm molded into a blaster, but instead of firing the casing receded to reveal the energy source beneath. A green light shined out from Tara’s arm. The inner casing extended upward increasing the output of light.

Serbenet shrieked as the tongue retracted and the maw closed. The darkness receded to form a wall facing Tara and the crowd of people running away. Tendrils spit out, slamming against the ground spewing up chunks of the road. The tendrils smacked against the masses of concrete in the air, and they flew toward Tara and the crowd.

Moments before, Momentum landed on the ground as Burnout ran out from a building and sat a child on the ground who started running away. Burnout bent forward and rested their hands

on their knees as they gasped for air. Momentum wiped the back of his glove against his head.

He looked forward to see the flash of green light as Serbenet remolded to form the wall. Momentum's eyes opened wide when he saw the concrete fly toward them. He tackled Burnout to the ground and they both watched as a chunk of the road slammed against a building they hadn't reached yet. A man leaning out of the window to that building was knocked into the air and the base of the building rumbled.

"We gotta move!" Momentum shouted. He shot his anchor upward and blasted through the air grabbing the man. Burnout took a deep breath then ran into the building. They started with one family, but as Burnout kept moving through the building they found more and more people who had tried to stay in their apartments and wait out the fight.

Momentum landed on the ground and set the man down who began running to safety. He met each person as Burnout dropped them off outside. As soon as each person realized they had been dropped off, Momentum gave them a nudge and they started running down the street. He watched as one family multiplied into ten and they kept being dropped off. There had to have been more people in this building than any of the others. He looked at the base and read the sign.

"Outer Skum Apartments . . . APARTMENTS . . . crap," he said. Momentum looked to the side of the sign and saw the crack



spread across the building. The building began to slide forward crumbling as it fell off its foundation.

Tara flew against the side of the building and pushed into it, keeping it from moving forward. Boosters formed at her feet and their force combined with her jetpack kept the building from moving.

“BURNOUT! YOU GOTTA MOVE! THE PLACE IS COMING DOWN!” Momentum shouted.

Burnout heard his pleading slowly be pronounced as they ran through each room scanning for any person. They were moving with such speed now that they did not even open the doors, instead instantly burning a hole in them as they moved into each room. Of the twenty floors, Burnout had cleared up through floor seventeen when Momentum made his request. There were still three floors of people left. There was too much left to stop.

Tara’s boosters burned brighter as the building continued to try and slide forward. Burnout darted in and out of the building still emptying people, now through the eighteenth floor. A tendril wrapped around Tara’s ankle and ripped her away from the building. Momentum watched as it slowly slid forward again. He reached for his grappling system.

“COME ON! TIME IS UP! YOU GOT TO GET OUT OF THERE!”

Burnout was through the nineteenth floor when he said this. *No, I can save them all. No one dies today.* Burnout moved through

the final floor and found one last kid left. They grabbed the kid and a quilt, then blasted down the stairs. When Burnout ran out the front door, they saw that the building was now only seconds from toppling down on them. With the kid weighing them down, there was no way to run out of it in time. Burnout wrapped the kid in the quilt and threw them, so they landed outside of the building's shadow.

Fractions of a moment before, Momentum waited at the entrance with his finger on the trigger and watched as the red blur burst from the building and a clothed lump flew out of the building's shadow. Momentum pressed down on the right trigger then the left. The right anchor shot out and wrapped around Burnout's ankle. It zipped back so Burnout was now right next to him. The left anchor dug into a building outside of the collapse. Momentum grabbed a hold of Burnout and held them against his chest as the back of his suit grinded against the ground.

Dust cascaded down covering the exit preventing him from knowing how close they were to getting out. The gears in his belt grinded against the metal cord. Sparks flew out from behind them as they skid across the ground. Chunks of rock fell from the building covering their path out. Within only fractions of a second, Momentum kicked his feet against the ground, knocking them to the side so they would avoid the obstacles. He watched as the building grew closer and closer to them, now no more than a second from pushing against them.

“Quick! That’s our student in there! Hold this building up!”

The building stopped moving and Momentum slid out into the moonlight. His anchor ripped out of the building. He and Burnout tumbled across the ground. Before he could pick himself up, he was lifted up, and saw that Tensile was holding him.

Bat, Rider, Dragonfly, Pillbug-Man, and Philosopher stood at the side of the building.

“THERE HE IS! Nice work there!” Pillbug-Man said.

Philosopher ran over to Burnout and slowly picked them up.

“That was dumb of you, we could have both died,” Burnout said.

“But we didn’t,” Momentum said.

“Thank you,” Burnout said.

“How did you all hold up that building?” Momentum asked.

“It was mostly me,” Pillbug-Man said.

“It was mostly Bat,” Rider said. Bat howled in agreement.

“Well, we more just lifted up a small fragment of the building, that which you were still under,” Dragonfly said.

“Wait, Tara is still fighting Serbenet alone!” Momentum said.

“You, Burnout, pleasure to meet you finally, and Tensile go help her. We will cover civilians,” Pillbug-Man said.

“Wait—,” Burnout began to say.

“Don’t worry. You can trust them to keep everyone safe. We got this,” Momentum said.

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“Teen Demon, you must wake up.”

Teen Demon was awoken by a jolt of energy surging through his body.

“Ow, Markie, I was going to finish healing eventually,” Teen Demon said as he sat back up. A pink aura covered the ground and when he looked to the sky Teen Demon saw Mindmeld floating in the air. Microcosm and Tinkerer were hovering in the air like lifeless puppets each lifted by a strand of pink electricity connected to Mindmeld holding them.

“What is that?” Teen Demon asked.

“I think he is making a neural network.”

“Why would he do that?”

“Perhaps he is able to share the memories between all three bodies, lessening the burden on one individual.”

“YOU’re partialLy right. WhILe this is a network, it’s noT just to share, but to play.”

“There’s still time to stop this. Just put them down, Andy!” Teen Demon said.

Tinkerer flew forward in the air, so she was hovering just in front of Teen Demon. She opened her mouth to speak, but it was not her voice, “Teen Demon, please go speak to the villains all day. I can’t bear you being in the house, Honey.”

“Do not speak for her.”

Microcosm drifted through the air until her limp body hovered in front of Markie. Her eyes were closed, but her mouth moved to speak with a voice, “I don’t even view you as a human, I would have never told a human those things about myself.”

“That’s enough, Mindmeld!”

“I think i HAVe the auThority to spEak on their BEhalf, all thINGs considered.”

“Why aren’t you taking us too then?”

“Because we are useless to him.”

“tRUE, but i still must fiNd sometNing tO do With you. i NEED more memories and YOU are in my way!”

Teen Demon reached for his earpiece to call for help, but it had been fried when the electricity cooked his body. Mindmeld floated down to the ground. As he walked toward Markie and Teen Demon, he left imprints on the grass blades that briefly flashed pink before catching fire. Mindmeld raised his hand up.

Teen Demon swung his sword against the ground. A splatter of rocks and dirt sprung upward blocking the electricity that flew off Mindmeld.

“I think the excess of mental energy is causing this. If you can keep him busy, I can extract it.”

Teen Demon nodded then dove to the side to avoid another blast of electricity. As Markie hovered away, he rolled against the ground. Mindmeld kicked his feet against the ground and two skis made of electricity slid against the ground. Teen Demon dug his tail

into the ground and flung himself upward and away from the skis. As he flew through the air, a massive wrench made of electricity spun outward from Mindmeld's hand and into him. Teen Demon went flying backward into a tree.

Mindmeld calmly walked forward; Tinkerer and Microcosm's body still hovering in the air just a few feet behind him. Teen Demon opened his eyes only for everything to appear blurry. He held his hand against his head, and it was wet. Teen Demon's hand was up against his brain. A chunk of his head had flown off during the collision and blood was streaming over his eyes.

"Oh—That is not good."

"you Push and you push and you push. you keep interacting with others because you need to. just Like you tAlk to tara. juSt likeE you talk to beekeeper. juST like you talk to wendigO woman—"

"It's . . . it's Claire."

"—you need their validation. if you don't keeP doing things for others, trying to help theM, thEn for just one moment you maybe had to sIt with who you Are. if you don't hear froM aT least one peRson everY day that you are a good person, then It is just like yesterday. but what you caN't seem to Get through your head is how transparent this all is."

Mindmeld raised his hand into the air. An exact replica of Teen Demon's sword made of pink energy formed in his hands. He stabbed it through Teen Demon's stomach and into the tree trunk.

“they don’t even know you’re real name. i do. it is pronounceable.”

“Please . . . don’t . . .”

“i’LL spell It out Like thIs as There is someone Hiding. did you think that angel had summoned you to her side at random? no. she chose you for who you are! she knew and i am going to get that through your skull.”

A pink book appeared in Mindmeld’s hands. He swung it left, colliding with Teen Demon’s mask. Grey matter sprayed onto an adjacent tree. He swung it right, crashing into the mask. With each blow, pieces chipped off it. The mask’s large eyes crumbled away, and its sharp teeth were grinded to nothingness. Mindmeld reached forward and ripped the mask off the front of Teen Demon’s head.

Teen Demon’s real face was small. He had two little black dots for eyes, two notches where his nose would be, and thin lips around his mouth. Mindmeld stood above Teen Demon whose body shook. Teen Demon sniffled and wiped the blood away. Mindmeld looked at his brother’s real face, pummeled and with a chunk missing from the back.

Mindmeld reached his hand up and Markie zipped out from the woods. She raised her arm forward and a wire flew out of it. The prong at the end of it impaled Mindmeld in his back. Pink electricity began surging through the wire and into Markie. Her eyes turned

pink. Mindmeld reached behind and ripped the cord out. He watched as Markie's body vibrated with energy.

"how doeS it feel tO expeRience only a fRaction of mY power?"

"Systems at 389%. Manual output needed."

Markie looked at Mindmeld, Teen Demon, Microcosm, and Tinkerer in front of her. She looked behind herself and saw the house. Markie flew up into the sky and raised her arms. Mindmeld and Teen Demon watched as the sky turned pink.

~~~

Tara spun around Serbenet with her blasters shining into the mass of darkness. He slicked away from the light pooling in the shadows of buildings and wrapping around Tara's back as she flew.

Momentum landed on the other side of the collapsed building and dropped Tensile. Burnout appeared next to them followed by a burst of wind.

"Serbenet?" Tensile asked.

"Yeah," Momentum said.

Tensile reached into her pocket, grabbed her phone, turned on its flashlight, then set it in a pocket on her suit.

"Okay. Burnout, you run circles on the ground creating light with your electricity. Tara will cover the sky."

"Won't he go into the buildings to find darkness?" Momentum asked. Burnout disappeared and reappeared next to them.



“These buildings are empty,” Burnout said.

“Good. I will wait in the building on the left side of the street, and Momentum will wait in the right. Once Serbenet is in a building that person has to keep them busy while we pinch him. We can’t leave an opening large enough for his human body to sneak through,” Tensile said.

“What if he goes into your building, Tensile? You’re just going to fight him with a scarf?” Burnout asked.

Tensile took the scarf off from around her neck.

“Damn right I will.”

“Fair enough. Consider the ground covered,” Burnout said before disappearing in a burst of energy.

“COVER THE SKY!” Momentum shouted to Tara. He ran into the right building. Tensile ran into the left building. As a red aura spread across the ground, Tara slammed her fists together. Her two arms molded together, and the blaster grew even larger.

“Reroute the maximum amount of power possible to the blasters,” she said. She flew to the side of the building then her jetpack molded back into her back and two arms formed at her side with blades at the end of them. She anchored herself into the building with her spare arms as the light grew brighter. It was difficult to see through Serbenet, but she could swear Burnout was spelling “Screw off” in the ground with her pathing.

Serbenet condensed into a mass of darkness no larger than a truck and molded into a spiral. He began spinning and dug into the

left building. Tensile was on the second floor when Serbenet drilled through the window to the hallway. His body reformed into something resembling a bear with the mouth of a shark and the darkness formed a wall blocking out the window.

“Hmm. I guess I picked wrong.”

Tensile ran to the stairs as Serbenet thrashed toward her. She flicked on lights as she ran, but spikes shot up from Serbenet shattering the bulbs as soon as they were lit. The hallway was pitch black and whether Serbenet had control of it all yet was beyond her.

Momentum ran out from the right building.

“Which floor did he go into?”

“The second!” Tara shouted.

“You two keep spinning around the building, we can’t let him get out of it.”

Burnout nodded and dashed away.

“Okay, be careful,” Tara said before reforming her jetpack and blasting off.

Momentum shot his anchor into the fourth floor’s window and crashed into it, rolling to a stop inside. He began running to the stairs.

Tensile burst through the door to what she hoped was the stairwell and was greeted by dim yellow lights coloring concrete stairs. After looking up to see the dozens of floors above, she whipped her scarf onto the railing of the third floor and swung up to

it as Serbenet crashed against the walls of the staircase. She jumped up to the fourth floor but was pulled down by a clawed hand.

Momentum burst open the door to the staircase and reached his arm out to Tensile. She grabbed on and he swung her up to the fifth level before using his grappling hooks to fly up to the sixth level. They worked together to swing up the floors as Serbenet spiraled below them viciously swiping upward.

“I don’t know if we can make it all the way up!” Momentum shouted.

“We don’t have to. I just need to get up high!” Tensile shouted.

Within seconds they had made it to the twelfth floor.

“I need an anchor,” she said. Momentum loosened the chord attached to one of the anchors and passed the end of it to Tensile.

“Count to five then wind it up.” She flipped backward off the staircase and spiraled downward into the darkness falling between the shadow’s claws. One.

For a brief moment, everything was black. Two. She found him in the darkness. Three. Tensile whipped her scarf out and wrapped it around Serbenet’s human body dragging him downward with her. Four. They fell past the floors. Once they crossed the third floor Tensile threw him downward and Serbenet crashed against the floor. Five. Tensile zipped back upward to the twelfth floor and she landed right next to Momentum.

The shadows instantly seeped back to the corners and cracks of the building as Serbenet groaned below.

Tensile and Momentum walked out of the building and into the morning sky with Serbenet's hands tied together. Tara landed next to them, and Burnout slid to a stop.

"See. We still got time for milkshakes," Burnout said.

"Erm, I don't know about that one," Momentum said as he pointed to the sun cresting over the horizon.

"You okay?" Tara asked looking at Momentum.

Before Momentum could speak, Tensile said, "Yeah, I assumed he was going to pick my building anyway."

"Those laser cannons were pretty cool," Momentum said.

"Thanks," Tara said.

"Detecting elevated heartrate. Should I initiate defense protocols?" her suit asked.

"No. Please don't do that," she said.

Everyone went quiet and stared at Tara.

"Sorry, just suit things," she said.

"Your suit is alive?" Tensile asked.

"Yeah."

"Pretty cool," Tensile said.

Pillbug-Man climbed over the debris and ran toward them.

"Woah! Crossover! Tell me, how did my students perform?" Pillbug-Man asked.

"I think we made a good team," Burnout said.

“Well, they have some good role models! Oh, and look at you. Always nice to find a fellow bug-themed hero. You have such wonderful taste,” Pillbug-Man said as he extended his hand out toward Tara.

She shook his hand as she said, “Got it from my dad.”

“Then he too has wonderful taste,” Pillbug-Man said.

The sky lit up pink briefly, interrupting their conversation.

“Hmm. That was pretty and perhaps poetic,” Pillbug-Man said.

“That came from the farm! I need to check in on my family!” Tara said. The back of her suit molded into a jetpack, and she flew into the sky.

Pillbug-Man turned toward Burnout then asked, “Tell me, Burnout. My understanding is you have been doing this all alone. Would you like a team?”

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“i’lL spell It out Like thIs as There is someone Hiding. did you think that angel had summoned you to her side at random. no. she chose you for who you are! she knew and i am going to get that through your skull.”

Mindmeld flew backward and slid across a shallow pond. He looked through a large window covering the entire right half of the room and saw Teen Demon sprawled out against the side of a tree. Mindmeld looked back to his left and saw the Director dragging his feet across the pebbled floor as he stepped closer. The room they

were stuck in was pitch black and the ceiling could not be seen, instead only darkness above was visible.

The diameter of the room they were trapped in had to be no larger than fifteen meters. Around them, ten doors sat on the perimeter of the circle. Each was a different color: maroon, orange, violet, aquamarine, red, blue, lime, yellow, pink, and dark green. On the dark green colored door, there appeared to be a black outline of Teen Demon. The yellow door had dozens of black bees etched onto it. This pattern carried on for each door, but the pink one only had an outline of a boy. A faint light matching the color of each door radiated off them and shined on the water.

Mindmeld watched through the window as his own arms swung a book against Teen Demon's head. Green gore splattered outward with each blow.

"Don't worry, we both know it won't kill him. Hope you don't *mind* that I stopped by. I wanted to see the fruits of my labor," the Director said. He now stood next to Mindmeld.

"I don't understand. If we're both here then who is doing that," Mindmeld said.

"That out there is realization."

"No, it doesn't make sense. You shouldn't even be here. I never absorbed your memories," Mindmeld said. He wiped the water off his face.

"There's more than one way to leave an imprint."

Mindmeld lunged forward at the Director legs. The Director sidestepped then slammed the back of his foot against Mindmeld's hand crushing them against the sediment floor. Mindmeld yelled out in pain.

"Go ahead. Call him. Call him! I want to see him," the Director said.

Stupendous Man burst forward out of the darkness and flew toward the Director, but he was stopped before his fist could connect. The water surged upward and molded into Mark-1 whose glaive was now stuck in Stupendous Man's stomach. Mark-1 lifted him into the air.

**". . . and let me introduce Rosewood to Mark Two!"**

Mark-1 pushed the back of the glaive into the ground then grabbed Stupendous Man by his head and legs. Stupendous Man's screams turned into groans as his skin ripped to reveal the bolts and screws that plopped into the water one by one. Mark-1 threw Stupendous Man into the water then disappeared back into the pools.

Teen Demon ran out from the darkness. He leapt into the air and dove toward the Director. His head exploded and his body rolled past the Director kicking up water as his limbs spun in circles. Microcosm appeared at the Director's side then receded into the pools.

Tinkerer stepped out of the shadows, but before she could make any distance her body seized as pink electricity flowed through it. She fell forward splashing water up. Mindmeld watched

a copy of himself step out of the shadows behind her then dive back into the water.

“We can keep going with Markie and Tara if you’d like,” the Director said.

Mindmeld looked around and stared at the two halves of Stupendous Man, the headless body of Teen Demon, and Tinkerer’s body with smoke still rising off it. He stood back up and stared at the Director.

“No. This isn’t how it’s going to end,” Mindmeld said.

“This is exactly how it was always going to end. Once your body takes care of those two nuisances, we can finish absorbing Tinkerer and Microcosm. It’s too late now. You’ve reached a tipping point. The powers control you and they aren’t afraid to reach their maximum potential. They know what it will take.

“Once we are done here, you’ll be so strong that no hero could stop you. You’ll finally be powerful, and it was all because of me!”

“You’re talking complete nonsense. My powers aren’t alive. They don’t think like Tara’s suit,” Mindmeld said.

“As always, you think too small. This is on an atomic . . . I daresay cosmic level. We are talking about energy seeking itself out in the universe. A plant leaning toward the sun. Water cutting rock to ravine. Electrons looking to fill a shell.”



“But if it’s my powers that are causing this right here then you failed. I never did reach realization. It’s all just some artificial chain reaction,” Mindmeld said.

“Maybe. Maybe not.”

“Teen Demon and Markie will stop me.”

The Director smacked Mindmeld with the back of his hand and Mindmeld spiraled against the floor of the pond kicking up water.

“No, they won’t . . . so how about YOU DO SOMETHING ABOUT—”

Mindmeld watched as the Director froze in place.

“how doeS it feel tO expeRience only a fRaction of mY power?”

A shadow appeared behind Mindmeld and said, “They can add layers, but they can never replace the foundation.” The shadow spun around to the front of Mindmeld’s body and placed its hand on his forehead before disappearing.

“Systems at 389%. Manual output needed.”

Another shadow appeared and placed its hand on Mindmeld’s forehead, “You can be more than what he tells you to be. Do that.”

The entire room flashed pink. Another shadow placed its hand on Mindmeld’s forehead.

“May you one day forgive us for what we have done to you. I only hope we give you the power to take it all back.”

The pink faded.

“Yuck, I hate people who undermine,” the Director said as he watched the shadow disappear. Mindmeld ran forward and punched the Director. He flew backward and skid against the rocks. Before he could pick himself up, Mindmeld began dragging him by the shirt.

“You want to play mind games, let’s go.”

Mindmeld pulled the Director up to the orange door and threw him through it. The Director tumbled onto a sparring mat. He watched Mindmeld step onto the mat. An orange light shined down above reflecting off his hair.

The Director ran forward and threw a punch. Mindmeld dodged it, grabbed hold of his fist, and threw the director over himself. As the director hit the ground, it erupted into a mass of papers that he fell through. The director landed in a library filled with aquamarine spined books.

Mindmeld erupted from one of the bookshelves and crashed against the Director knocking him into a bookshelf. The Director fell through the bookshelf and down a slope tumbling through the snow under the blue sky.

Once the Director landed at the bottom of the hill Mindmeld ran up and slammed two pads onto his chest and cranked the dials all the way up on the AED. A red light flashed over them as Mindmeld turned the AED on. When the shock subsided, it was apparent the Director was now in a classroom.

A violet chalkboard creaked as it began falling and the Director staggered backward. A plume of chalk dust burst into the air. The Director coughed as it filled his lungs. A lime spotlight shined through the cloud and a drumstick flew out colliding with his face. As he stumbled, the lime light was replaced with a maroon spotlight. Mindmeld appeared in the cloud and crashed a wrench against the Director's face.

A swarm of bees flew through the dust brushing it all away to reveal that they were both now standing on the plains of Hell surrounded by mountains lined with flames. A dark-green sword appeared in Mindmeld's hand. He threw it forward and the blade impaled the Director. He was flung backward, and the tip of the blade dug into a tree.

The Director laid impaled against the side of a tree. To the left of him, a young boy sat nestled in the roots talking to Lavender Lad. To the right of him, Teen Demon sat with his head bashed to pieces.

The room around them returned to that shallow pond with only the tree and those around it sitting in the water.

"Too many people have given too much for me to crumble now," Mindmeld said.

Stuck to the tree, the Director tilted his head to look at the boy.

"Kind of . . . interesting . . . we never did see what . . . was behind that pink door."

“Andrew has always been there helping,” Mindmeld said, looking down at his pink shirt.

“You finally embraced who you are. I knew you could do it, Guarav,” the Director said.

“No! You didn’t win today! I became something . . . I am something. I don’t know what it is, but it isn’t what you wanted me to be!”

“If you insist. See you in your memories,” the Director said as the room faded around them.

Outside, Mindmeld’s body remained motionless after the pink light flashed over the sky. Once the light faded, Markie descended back to the ground. The energy holding up Tinkerer and Microcosm faded, and Markie caught them as they fell. She set them down on the ground and flew over to Teen Demon, Mindmeld remained motionless.

Teen Demon’s head had healed, but his face was to the ground as he searched for fragments of his mask. Tara came into view and landed on the ground next to them.

She looked around then asked, “What happened here?”

“Mindmeld’s power bested him. The flash was me extracting some of the excess energy, but I am unsure if that was enough.”

Markie hovered over to Mindmeld and pressed her left arm against his back. Energy began surging through her and she raised her right arm into the air. A pink beam shined up into the sky.

Tara grabbed a piece of Teen Demon's mask and ran over to him.

"Don't look at me, please." Teen Demon said.

"I—I'm so sorry about all of this. You know you don't have to hide who you are from me, right?"

"I know. Just . . . let me be for a bit."

Tara set the piece down next to Teen Demon then ran over to Tinkerer who laid unconscious on the ground. As she assessed the damage to Tinkerer, Mindmeld collapsed to the ground.

Tara could hear him say just one sentence, "I'm . . . I'm sorry."

"It is not your fault," Markie said. Her hand did not move, and energy continued surging into the sky. Tara watched the pink beam pierce the sky as the sun rose in the distance.

## Epilogue

Tinkerer, Pillbug-Man, Abraham, and Blademaster sat around her dining room table. It was nighttime and the ceiling light was the only source of light in the room.

“Do you have any orange spice tea? I do love that flavor,” Abraham asked. Tinkerer nodded and grabbed a bag out of the cabinet that she gave to him.

“How are Microcosm and Burnout settling in with you, Pillbug-Man?” Tinkerer asked.

“Excellently. I actually think Morgan’s talents would be better served as a teacher rather than a student.”

“That’s great to hear,” Tinkerer said.

Pillbug-Man poured out some water from the teapot over his peppermint flavored teabag. Blademaster sat his cup, filled with black tea, down on his plate then rubbed his eyes.

“Jesus. It was worse than I could have ever fathomed,” Blademaster said.

“Maybe I should have scheduled a meeting with you, Abraham,” Tinkerer said.

“Don’t beat yourself up. I doubt there is much I could have done. I am a therapist, not a magician. This is not some common form of neurodivergence.”

“Then maybe one of your magician friends could have done something about it,” Tinkerer said.

“Things tend to go awry when magicians mess with the mind,” Abraham said.

“We can’t ignore the fact that no one died,” Pillbug-Man said.

Blademaster got up and began pacing the room. “Just barely. I’m afraid that this is a grim reminder of what is left from the last age of heroes. Look at us. We have a reformed villain, the altruistic wife of a hero, a therapist, and a former cult leader,” Blademaster said.

“You know I don’t like being referred to like that,” Tinkerer said.

“But the point still stands,” Blademaster said.

“I think that’s a brutal oversimplification of our state of affairs. There is more than just us, look no farther than the Nexus Magistrate,” Abraham said.

“The Nexus Magistrate?” Blademaster asked.

“I can’t tell you much about them, but just know they’re a team of capable supernatural experts operating within the shadows keeping the world in order,” Abraham said.

“Is Bliant still leading the crew?” Pillbug-Man asked.

“Indeed,” Abraham said.

“There’s always the Protectors for Profit,” Tinkerer said.

“I’ve been keeping an eye on them. It’s not quite time to pull them into the fold,” Pillbug-Man said.

“So, there are a total of two teams to reach out to: a secretive underground operation and a small business?”

Pillbug-Man took a sip from his cup then said, “Back to what you said earlier, I think we are just looking at the last age of heroes *so far*. There are nearly a dozen powerful, compassionate young heroes just the people in this room know of and there are likely countless more that we are unaware of.”

“That’s great, but what are we going to do when Atomsplitter gets out, because it’s only a matter of time? She thinks Justice is alive and we have nothing comparable to throw against her,” Blademaster said.

The room fell silent. Only the grandfather clock ticking could be heard.

“We will work together,” Pillbug-Man said.

“How do we know that will work?” Blademaster asked.

“Because it will have to. As long as I live, I will work with the Nexus Magistrate to aid with these fights,” Abraham said.

“We are at a pivot point in history. The Alpha Squadron failed, and we have been feeling the repercussions of that for decades, but enough time has passed for us to make something of this all. We can take the mistakes of the past generation and use it to train the next to be even better.

“The Academy will be with you, Tinkerer, when she returns,” Pillbug-Man said.



“Well, I was never going to miss a chance to kill that blue stain anyway,” Blademaster said.

“This is our fight. My family caused this. No one else has to put themselves on the line,” Tinkerer said.

“You have only the villain to blame,” Abraham said.

“Helping is what heroes do. We’re like arches supporting anything above them with no prejudice and the more arches the stronger a bridge is,” Pillbug-Man said as he drew a semicircle in the air.

“That analogy is a bit of a stretch,” Blademaster said.

“I’m thinking it’s going to catch on.”